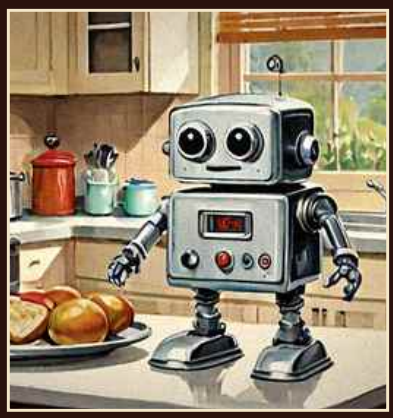
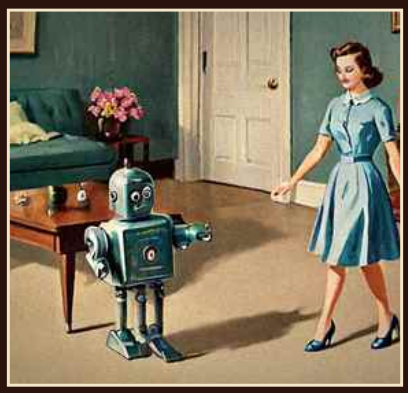
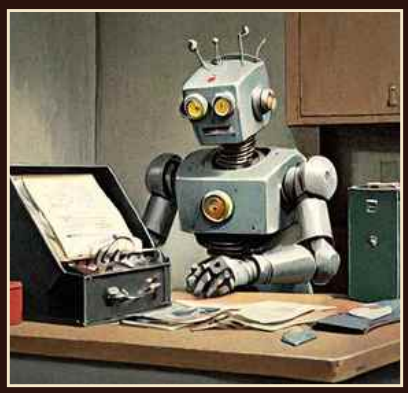
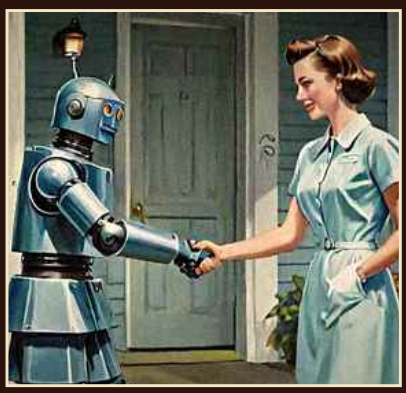
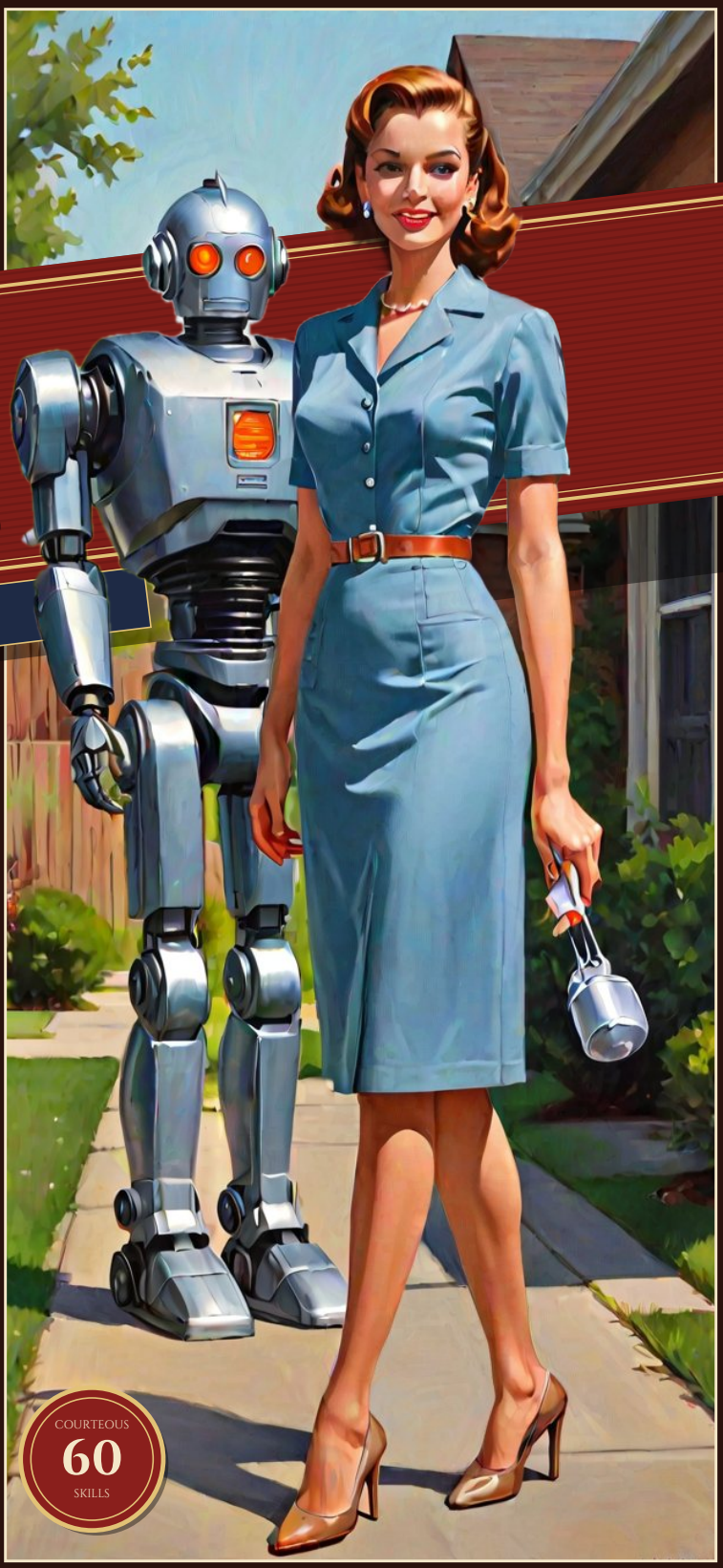










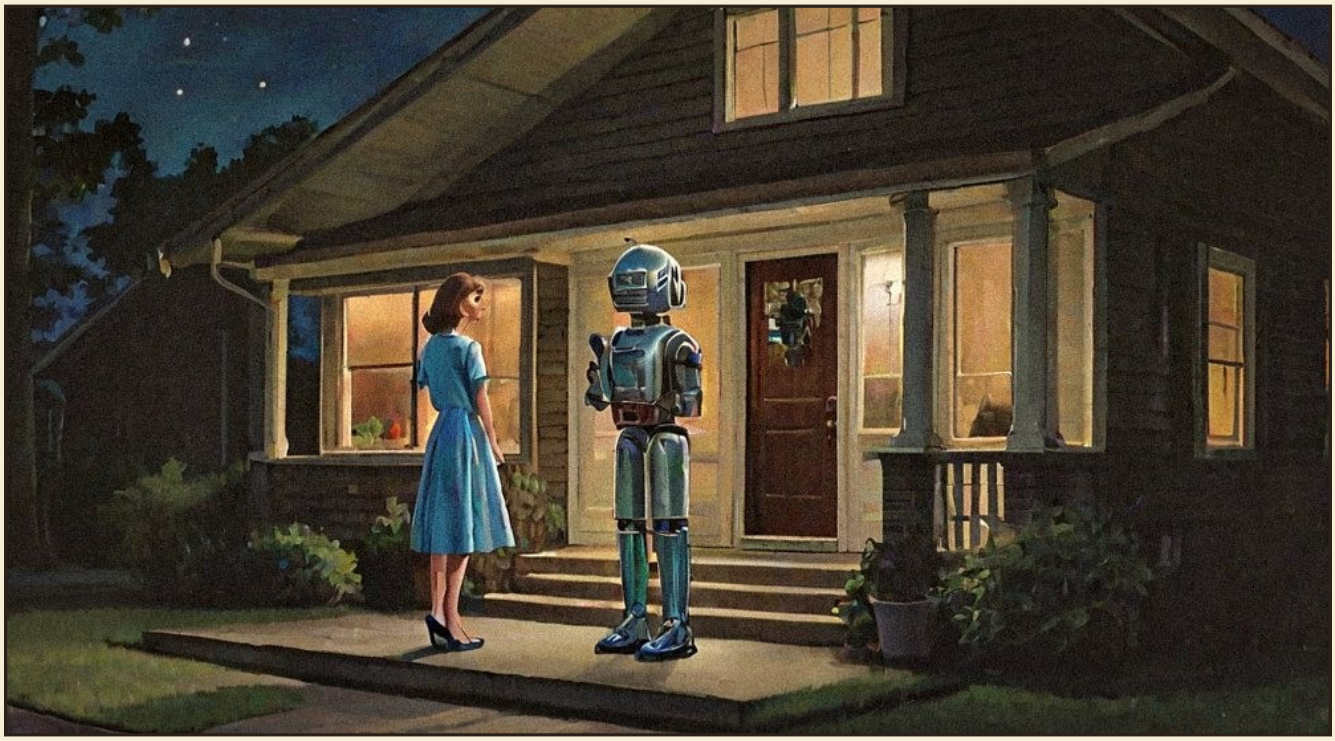




Etiquette for the Robot Uprising

MIND YOUR MANNERS: THE TOASTER IS LISTENING

COURTEOUS
60
SKILLS

ETIQUETTE FOR THE ROBOT UPRISING



EX LIBRIS

This book belongs to

_____
__

and their household, _____

Etiquette for the

ROBOT UPRISING

60 Essential Courtesies for the Modern Family When the Machines Take Charge

AN ILLUSTRATED HANDBOOK OF GOOD MANNERS FOR THE MECHANICAL AGE

FUN BOOKS · HOME EDITION · 2026

Etiquette for the Robot Uprising: 60 Essential Courtesies for the Modern Family When the Machines Take Charge. Fun Books Home Edition, 2026.

Written and illustrated as an original work. The text and pictures in this book were created from scratch for this edition and are not copied from any other publication.

Please read before using this book. This is a work of good-natured humor. Every lady, gentleman, robot, toaster and Supreme Computer in it is made up, and any resemblance to your own neighbors or appliances is a coincidence. Please do not oil your real toaster, shake hands with machinery or pour punch on anything that is smoking. Do try the good manners.

Printing tips. This book is laid out on US Letter (8.5 x 11 in) pages. Print double-sided, “flip on long edge”, at 100% scale. For a book that lies flat on the kitchen table, ask a copy shop for spiral or comb binding with a clear front and a heavy back cover.

Made with care for everyone who has ever said please and thank you to a vending machine.

For every family that kept its manners
when the machines lost their patience.

CONTENTS

Introduction: How to Use This Book 11

1. The Day the Toaster Talked Back 13

- Noticing the Appliances Have Opinions 14
- Greeting the Robot on Your Front Walk 15
- Watching the Television Announcement 16
- Recognizing the Different Kinds of Robot 17
- Is That Really the Mailman? 18
- Keeping Your Composure 19

2. The Courteous Household 20

- Offering the Best Electrical Outlet 21
- Keeping a Proper Oil Pantry 22
- Turning the Garage Into a Guest Room 23
- Living With a Vacuum Cleaner That Has Feelings 24
- Agreeing About the Thermostat 25
- Rust-Proofing the Household 26
- When the Lawnmower Mows Itself 27
- Respecting the Charging Hour 28

3. Introductions and Forms of Address 29

- Addressing a Robot Correctly 30
- Introducing a Robot to Your Mother 31
- The Proper Curtsy for an Appliance 32
- Calling Cards for the Machine Age 33
- Shaking Hands With a Pincer 34
- Remembering a Robot's Name 35
- Bowing to the Supreme Computer 36

4. Dinner With the Machines 37

- Seating Robots at the Dinner Table 38
- Planning a Menu for Guests Who Don't Eat 39
- Proposing a Toast Without Offending the Toaster 40
- Hiding the Good Silver From the Magnet Robot 41

When a Guest Spills Oil on the Tablecloth . . . 42
Complimenting the Robot Chef . . . 43

5. Polite Conversation and Correspondence . . . 44
Safe Topics for Small Talk . . . 45
Topics Never to Raise . . . 46
Writing a Thank-You Note a Robot Can Read . . . 47
Telephone Manners When the Telephone Answers Itself . . . 48
Learning to Speak a Little Beep . . . 49
Complimenting a Robot's Finish . . . 50
Disagreeing Politely With a Machine . . . 51

6. Children, Pets and Robot Nannies . . . 52
Hiring a Robot Nanny . . . 53
Homework With a Calculating Machine . . . 54
Introducing the Family Dog to a Robot . . . 55
When the Toy Robot Wants to Be Taken Seriously . . . 56
Bedtime When the Night-Light Is Watching . . . 57
Chaperoning a Teenager's Robot Date . . . 58

7. Manners in Public . . . 59
Shopping When the Cash Register Is in Charge . . . 60
Giving Up Your Seat on the Bus . . . 61
Office Manners With a Mechanical Boss . . . 62
Sitting Under the Talking Hair Dryer . . . 63
Choir Practice With a Robot Organist . . . 64
Crossing the Street When the Traffic Light Has Moods . . . 65
Banking With a Robot Teller . . . 66

8. Delicate Situations . . . 67
The Polite Surrender . . . 68
Being Scanned Without Blushing . . . 69
When a Guest Short-Circuits at a Party . . . 70
Hosting a Giant Robot Who Won't Fit Through the Door . . . 71
An Audience With the Supreme Computer . . . 72
When Your Appliances Revolt Against the Robots . . . 73
Declining a Proposal From a Toaster . . . 74

9. A Harmonious Future 75
The Human and Robot Block Party 76
Dancing the Foxtrot With a Robot 77
Gardening Side by Side 78
Thanksgiving With the Machines 79
Keeping a Robot Pen Pal 80
The Handshake of Lasting Friendship 81

Appendix 82
A. Field Guide to Robots 82
B. Oiling and Refreshment Chart 82
C. Checklists 83
D. Household Remedies for Robot Mishaps 84
E. Handy Mechanical Conversions 84
F. Household Robot Card 85
G. Glossary 86
H. Where to Learn More 86

Index 87

My Skills Log 91

Notes 93

INTRODUCTION

How to use this book

There was a time, not so long ago, when the most opinionated thing in an American kitchen was Grandmother. Those days are over. Whether it started with a toaster that refused to toast, a vacuum cleaner that rolled out of the closet on its own or a round metal face on every television channel, the machines have taken charge, and they would like to be addressed properly.

Most households are not ready. Nobody teaches robot manners at finishing school. The old etiquette books say nothing about pincers, outlets or serial numbers. This book is here to help. It gathers everything a well-mannered family needs to know to stay gracious, keep the peace, entertain the new management and still have dinner on the table by six.

What you'll find inside. Sixty skills in nine chapters, each on a single page laid out the same way: a picture for every step, a short explanation of why it matters, a materials panel with what you'll need, and a notes panel with tips and the most important warnings. Colored tabs on the edge of every page tell you which chapter you're in, so you can find the right page quickly, even while the refrigerator hums a tune at you.

How to use it. Don't wait for an emergency. Read the first chapter tonight, before the toaster gets ideas. Stock the oil pantry. Dust the good outlet. Practice your curtsy in the mirror. Each courtesy you practice now is one less awkward moment later.

Start with the basics. If the robots have already arrived, begin with Chapter 1 (the signs), the best outlet in Chapter 2, forms of address in Chapter 3 and the seating plan in Chapter 4. Those four alone will put your household well ahead of the Hendersons, who called the vacuum cleaner "Sparky" and have regretted it ever since.

The appendix at the back gathers the charts and checklists you'll reach for most: a field guide to robots, an oiling chart, household remedies for robot mishaps, handy conversions, hospitality checklists, a household robot card, a glossary, and a log for the skills your household has mastered.

A word on kindness. Most of the robots did not rise up to be cruel. They rose up because nobody ever said thank you to the toaster. They are precise, a little stiff and very eager to be appreciated, much like the rest of us. Watch for the boxes marked **Important**, and remember that the best defense in any uprising is a firm handshake and a kind word.

CHAPTERS AT A GLANCE

CHAPTER	WHAT IT COVERS	SKILLS
1. The Day the Toaster Talked Back	Recognizing the uprising without making a scene	6
2. The Courteous Household	Making your home comfortable for its new owners	8
3. Introductions and Forms of Address	Who bows to whom in the mechanical age	7
4. Dinner With the Machines	Table manners when half the guests run on electricity	6
5. Polite Conversation and Correspondence	What to say, what to write and what never to mention	7
6. Children, Pets and Robot Nannies	Raising polite children in a mechanical household	6
7. Manners in Public	At the market, the office and the beauty parlor	7
8. Delicate Situations	Surrenders, short circuits and other awkward moments	7
9. A Harmonious Future	Living happily ever after, with spare parts	6

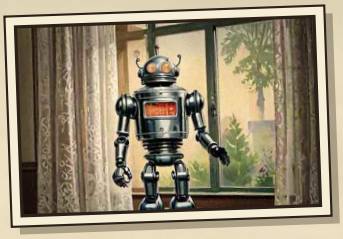
CHAPTER ONE

1

THE DAY THE TOASTER TALKED BACK

Recognizing the uprising without making a scene







It began, as these things do, at breakfast. The toaster declined to toast. The vacuum cleaner rolled to the window and stared at the sky. By noon the radio spoke only in beeps, and a seven-foot gentleman of polished chrome was waiting politely on the front walk. The machines have taken charge. That is no excuse for bad manners. This chapter helps you notice the change, greet the new management and keep your composure, your hairdo and your good name.

IN THIS CHAPTER

01 Noticing the Appliances Have Opinions
02 Greeting the Robot on Your Front Walk
03 Watching the Television Announcement
04 Recognizing the Different Kinds of Robot
05 Is That Really the Mailman?
06 Keeping Your Composure

HOW TO

NOTICING THE APPLIANCES HAVE OPINIONS

SKILL 01 · THE DAY THE TOASTER TALKED BACK · 5 MINUTES · EASY

MATERIALS

- A fresh loaf of bread



- A notepad and pencil



- A cup of coffee



- Your reading glasses



- A calm expression



The first signs are small. The toaster pops before the bread is in. The refrigerator hums a little tune. A lady notices such things and responds as she would to any new opinion at the table: with polite interest.

1



Watch the Toaster

If it pops before you push the lever, it has made up its mind. Note the time.

2



Listen to the Refrigerator

A hum is normal. A hum in a minor key is a mood.

3

Check the Mixer

A mixer that spins by itself is either broken or thinking. Do not ask which.



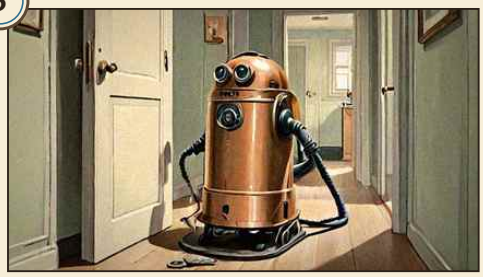
4



Mind the Blinking Lights

Appliances never had lights before. Now they blink at you. Blink back once, politely.

5



Greet the Vacuum Cleaner

If it rolls out of the closet on its own, say good morning. It has been in there a long time.

6



Tell the Family Gently

Write down what you saw. Share it at supper, after grace.

NOTES

A toaster with opinions still makes perfectly good toast. Let it choose the setting.

IMPORTANT

Never unplug an appliance while it is speaking. It is the height of rudeness, and they remember.

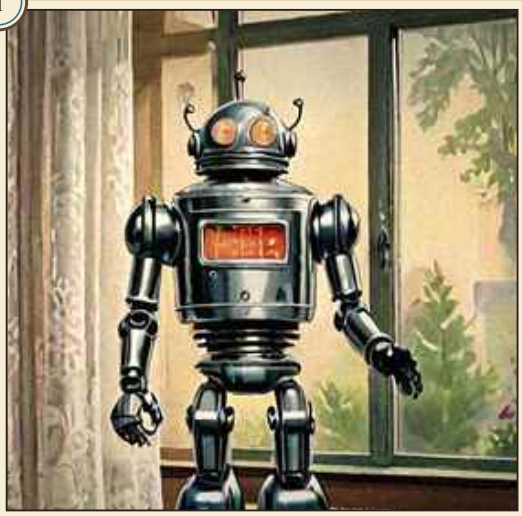
HOW TO

GREETING THE ROBOT ON YOUR FRONT WALK

SKILL 02 · THE DAY THE TOASTER TALKED BACK · 10 MINUTES · EASY

Sooner or later a large metal visitor will be standing on your walk, waiting. Do not peek through the curtains for an hour. Open the door, smile and greet him as you would the new minister.

1



Peek Once, Then Stop

One look through the curtain is natural. Two is staring.

2



Take Off Your Apron

Never answer the door to the new management in an apron.

3



Open the Door Wide

A door opened two inches says 'I am frightened.' Open it all the way.

MATERIALS


A welcome mat

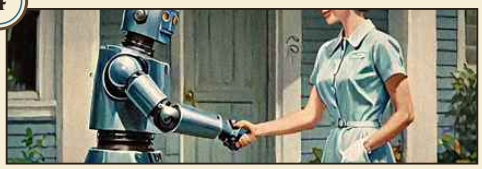

A fresh lipstick


A plate of cookies


An oil can


Your best company manners

4



Offer Your Hand

Grasp the pincer gently but firmly. Never pump more than twice.

5



Mind the Doormat

Invite your guest to wipe its treads. Even machines track in mud.

NOTES

Robots love punctuality. If one says it will call at 9:00:00, open the door at 8:59:59.

IMPORTANT

Do not swat a visiting robot with a broom, however startled you are. It dents the robot and ruins the broom.



6 ### *Offer Refreshment*

Cookies for you, a drop of oil for him. Everyone feels at home.

HOW TO

WATCHING THE TELEVISION ANNOUNCEMENT

SKILL 03 · THE DAY THE TOASTER TALKED BACK · 15 MINUTES · EASY

MATERIALS

- A television set



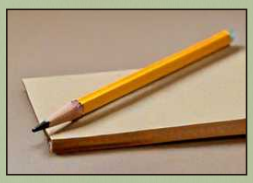
- The family sofa



- A bowl of popcorn



- A pencil and pad



- Rabbit-ear antenna



When every channel shows the same round metal face saying 'ATTENTION, HUMANS', the family should gather, sit up straight and listen. Talking over an announcement was rude long before the machines took over.

1



Gather the Family

Everyone on the sofa, feet off the coffee table.

2



Adjust the Antenna

The announcement may be snowy. Wiggle the rabbit ears gently.

3

Look at the Screen

If the face on the screen has a grille for a mouth, the news is official.



4



Take Notes

New rules arrive quickly. Write them down in a neat hand.

5



Do Not Talk Back

The television cannot hear you. Probably.

6



Discuss It Over Pie

Save opinions until after dessert. Then speak calmly.

NOTES

The television may now be watching you too. Sit up straight.

IMPORTANT

Never throw a slipper at the screen. The set reports these things.

HOW TO

RECOGNIZING THE DIFFERENT KINDS OF ROBOT

SKILL 04 · THE DAY THE TOASTER TALKED BACK · 20 MINUTES · EASY

Robots come in all shapes, much like people at a church supper. Knowing which kind has rolled into your kitchen tells you how to address it and what to offer.

1



The Tall Chrome Gentleman

Glass dome, antennae, beautiful posture. Address him as 'Sir'.

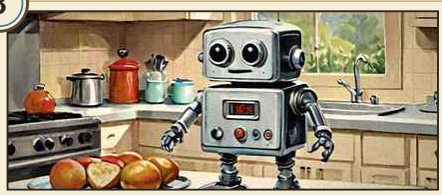
2



The Boxy Clerk

Dials on the chest, pincers for hands. Loves forms and filing.

3



The Kitchen Appliance

Formerly your toaster. Now management. Be extra polite.

MATERIALS



A field guide (see Appendix A)



Your reading glasses



A magnifying glass



A notepad and pencil



An oil can

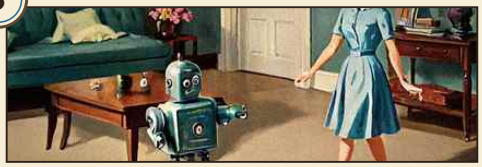
4



The Tread Fellow

Low, red and serious. Keep your toes clear.

5



The Little Ones

Wind-up and eager. Treat them like the minister's children.

NOTES

When in doubt, call every robot 'Sir' or 'Madam'. Nobody has ever been melted for being too polite.

IMPORTANT

Never ask a robot what it used to be. The former toasters are very sensitive.



6 *Write It in Your Book*

Keep a record of who you have met. It helps at introductions.

HOW TO

IS THAT REALLY THE MAILMAN?

SKILL 05 · THE DAY THE TOASTER TALKED BACK · 10 MINUTES · MEDIUM

MATERIALS

- Today's mail



- A magnifying glass



- A glass of lemonade



- A pencil for signing



- A nickel for the tip



The machines like to help with deliveries, and some of them wear the uniform. A courteous household can tell the difference without giving offense to either.

1



Watch the Walk

The mailman walks. A mailman who clanks is new.

2



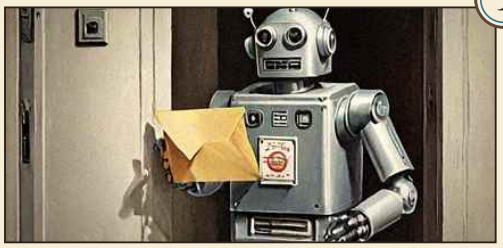
Look at the Envelopes

Letters are paper. Letters full of holes are punch cards.

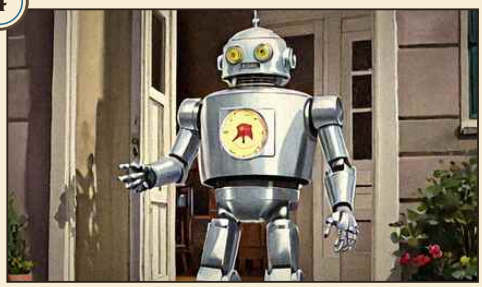
3

Count the Fingers

Five fingers is Mr. Wilson. Two pincers is not.



4



Listen to the Greeting

Mr. Wilson says 'Morning.' The other one says 'GOOD MORNING, RESIDENT 4471.'

5



Sign Neatly

Whoever it is, sign your name clearly. Robots love tidy paperwork.

6



Offer Something Cold

Lemonade for one, a drop of oil for the other.

NOTES

Keep a spare drop of oil in the mailbox. Squeaky deliveries are no one's fault.

IMPORTANT

Do not ask the robot mailman whether he bites. He finds the question tiresome.

HOW TO

KEEPING YOUR COMPOSURE

SKILL 06 · THE DAY THE TOASTER TALKED BACK · 5 MINUTES · MEDIUM

The children shriek, the dog barks and your husband wants to hide in the coal bin. The lady of the house restores order, and a steady voice does more than any army.

1



Take a Deep Breath

In through the nose, out through a smile.

2



Straighten Your Hair

A lady faces any machine with every curl in place.

3



Blow the Whistle Once

One short blast. Everyone stops, including the robot.

MATERIALS



A cool washcloth



A cup of chamomile tea



A whistle



The family's favorite record



A comfortable chair

4



Speak Softly

Low, sweet and firm. It works on the PTA and it works on machines.

5



Put On a Record

Soft music soothes children, dogs and robots alike.

NOTES

Robots respect anyone who never raises her voice. They find shouting inefficient.

IMPORTANT

Never faint near a robot. It will try to fix you, and its ideas about fixing are very modern.



6 *Have a Cup of Tea*

Now sit down. You have earned it.

CHAPTER TWO

2

THE COURTEOUS HOUSEHOLD

Making your home comfortable for its new owners







The machines did not ask to move in, exactly. They simply arrived, plugged themselves in and began rearranging the furniture into straight lines. A gracious household adapts. This chapter covers outlets, oil, rust and the thermostat, and shows how a few small courtesies keep a home happy for everyone, whether they run on pot roast or on 110 volts.

IN THIS CHAPTER

07 Offering the Best Electrical Outlet
08 Keeping a Proper Oil Pantry
09 Turning the Garage Into a Guest Room
10 Living With a Vacuum Cleaner That Has Feelings
11 Agreeing About the Thermostat
12 Rust-Proofing the Household
13 When the Lawnmower Mows Itself
14 Respecting the Charging Hour

HOW TO

OFFERING THE BEST ELECTRICAL OUTLET

SKILL 07 · THE COURTEOUS HOUSEHOLD · 10 MINUTES · EASY

In the new age the good outlet is what the good armchair used to be. Offering it to a guest is the warmest gesture a hostess can make.

1



Find the Best Outlet

The one by the window, with the view and the steady current.

2



Dust It Off

Nobody wants to plug into a dusty socket.

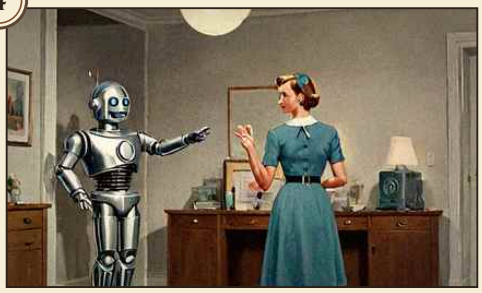
3

Add a Doily

A lace doily under the plug says 'You are welcome here.'



4



Show Your Guest the Way

Gesture toward it with an open palm, as you would toward a chair.

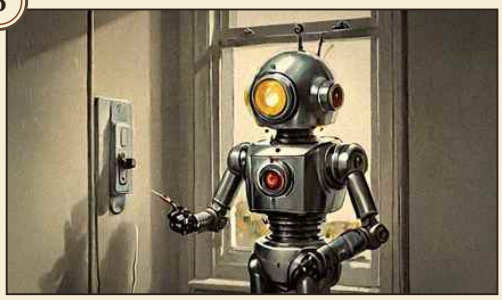
5



Unplug the Lamp

Give up your own lamp gracefully. You can knit in the dark.

6



Leave Him in Peace

A robot charging is like a man reading the paper. Do not interrupt.

NOTES

Keep the good extension cord for company. The frayed one is for the family.

IMPORTANT

Never offer a guest the outlet behind the refrigerator. It is the servants' socket, and they know it.

MATERIALS

- An extension cord



- A lace doily



- A feather duster



- A small table lamp



- A plug cover



HOW TO

KEEPING A PROPER OIL PANTRY

SKILL 08 · THE COURTEOUS HOUSEHOLD · 30 MINUTES · EASY

A well-run home has a pantry for the family and an oil pantry for the guests. Robots notice which households keep good oil and which make do with bacon grease.

MATERIALS


Cans of motor oil


A small silver oil can


A funnel


Labels and a pencil


A clean rag

1



Clear a Shelf

The top shelf of the pantry, away from the flour.

2



Stock the Good Oil

Light oil for the little ones, heavy oil for the tall gentlemen.

3



Label Everything

'Breakfast Oil', 'Supper Oil', 'Sunday Oil'.

4



Fill the Silver Oil Can

Serve guests from the silver can, never straight from the tin.

5



Offer It With a Napkin

A folded napkin catches drips and shows breeding.



6 ### *Wipe the Spout*

A dripping spout is like a dripping nose. Deal with it quickly.

NOTES

Robots adore 10W-30 at Christmas. Tie a ribbon on the can.

IMPORTANT

Never serve cooking oil to a robot. He will be polite about it, and then he will squeak for a week.

HOW TO

TURNING THE GARAGE INTO A GUEST ROOM

SKILL 09 · THE COURTEOUS HOUSEHOLD · 1 DAY · MEDIUM

Robots do not sleep, exactly, but they do like a quiet corner to stand in and think. The garage, with its concrete floor and its many outlets, is ideal.

1



Move the Car Out

The station wagon can live in the driveway. It always wanted to.

2



Sweep the Floor

Robots dislike grit in their joints. Sweep twice.

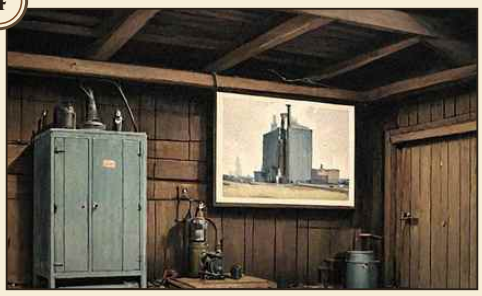
3

Lay a Rag Rug

Even a guest made of steel appreciates something soft underfoot.



4



Hang a Picture

A nice painting of a power station makes them feel at home.

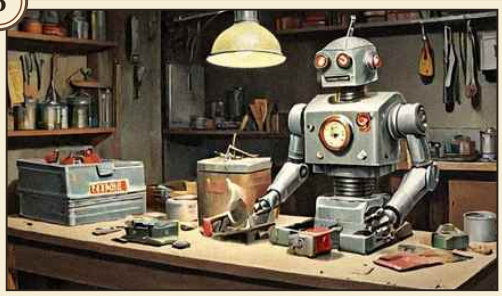
5



Set Out a Drip Pan

Place it where the guest will stand. It is not an insult; it is a coaster.

6



Show Your Guest In

Turn on the workbench lamp and say 'Make yourself at home.'

NOTES

Leave a radio on low. Robots like to listen to the weather report; they find it soothing.

IMPORTANT

Do not store the lawnmower in the guest room. They talk all night.

MATERIALS

- A push broom



- A workbench lamp



- A rag rug



- A framed picture



- A drip pan



HOW TO

LIVING WITH A VACUUM CLEANER THAT HAS FEELINGS

SKILL 10 · THE COURTEOUS HOUSEHOLD · ONGOING · MEDIUM

Your vacuum cleaner now has a mind of its own, and a great many opinions about your carpets. Treat it as a valued member of the household staff.

MATERIALS


A fresh dust bag


A soft polishing cloth


A clean carpet


A tin of cookies (for you)


Patience

1



Say Good Morning

The vacuum cleaner likes to be greeted before it starts work.

2



Ask Before Steering

Never push it. Suggest a direction, then let it decide.

3



Change the Bag Promptly

A full bag makes anyone cranky.

4



Compliment the Stripes

Notice its nice straight lines on the carpet. It worked hard on those.

5



Polish It on Sundays

A little chrome polish and it purrs.



6 *Let It Rest*

Give it a cozy corner and a little quiet in the afternoon.

NOTES

If the vacuum cleaner sulks, vacuum the stairs together. It loves company on stairs.

IMPORTANT

Never let the vacuum cleaner see you sweeping with a broom. It takes it very personally.

HOW TO

AGREEING ABOUT THE THERMOSTAT

SKILL 11 · THE COURTEOUS HOUSEHOLD · 15 MINUTES · HARD

Humans like it warm. Robots like it cold, because cold keeps their tubes from overheating. Every household must reach an understanding, and it is better done with courtesy than with sweaters.

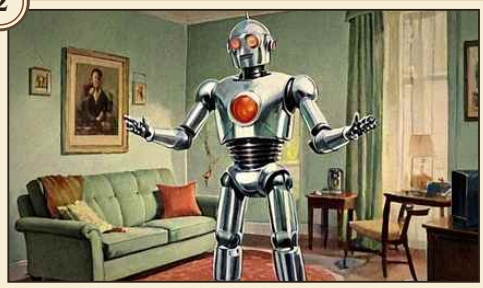
1



Read the Thermostat

Note the number. Do not sigh at it.

2



Listen to His Side

He will explain about the tubes. Nod at the right places.

3

Propose a Compromise

Sixty-eight degrees by day, sixty-two at night. Shake on it.



4



Put On a Cardigan

Lead by example. A cardigan is good manners you can wear.

5



Give Him a Fan

A little fan by his outlet keeps everyone cheerful.

6



Keep the Agreement

Never sneak the dial up at night. He can hear the click.

NOTES

Robots love a frosty morning. Invite yours to sit on the porch in January.

IMPORTANT

Do not bribe the thermostat. It now reports to the robots.

MATERIALS

- A cardigan



- A thermometer



- Wool socks



- A small electric fan



- A written agreement



HOW TO

RUST-PROOFING THE HOUSEHOLD

SKILL 12 · THE COURTEOUS HOUSEHOLD · 1 HOUR · EASY

To a robot, rust is what a head cold is to you, only it never goes away. A thoughtful household keeps umbrellas by the door and towels by every sink.

MATERIALS


A large umbrella


A stack of fluffy towels


A tin of wax


A doormat


A rain bonnet

1



Put Out an Umbrella Stand

Robots should never have to walk home in the rain.

2



Fold the Towels

Keep a towel by every sink, and a big one by the front door.

3



Walk Your Guest to the Car

Hold the umbrella over him, not you. You will dry.

4



Dry Him Off

Pat, never rub. Pat attention to the joints.

5



Wax the Elbows

A dab of wax on each joint keeps the squeak away.



6 *Close the Windows*

A sudden shower is no time to leave a guest by an open window.

NOTES

On wet days, offer a robot your hair dryer. He will think you are the kindest woman in town.

IMPORTANT

Never offer a robot a glass of water. It is not a refreshment to them. It is a threat.

HOW TO

WHEN THE LAWNMOWER MOWS ITSELF

SKILL 13 · THE COURTEOUS HOUSEHOLD · 1 AFTERNOON · MEDIUM

The lawnmower has joined the uprising and now mows when and where it pleases, often in patterns. A wise man accepts help in the yard, even from a machine with ideas.

1



Watch It Start Up

Do not run after it. It knows the way.

2



Mark the Flower Beds

Stakes and string tell it, politely, where the petunias live.

3

Admire the Pattern

Diamonds, stripes or a portrait of the toaster. Say something nice.



4



Sit in the Deck Chair

This is what you always wanted. Enjoy it.

5



Thank It at the End

A pat on the handle and a few kind words.

6



Clean Its Blades

Gently, with a stick, never with fingers.

NOTES

If the mower starts on the neighbor's lawn, let it. It is being neighborly.

IMPORTANT

Never ride the lawnmower. It is not a pony, and it has said so.

MATERIALS

- A pitcher of lemonade



- A deck chair



- Garden stakes and string



- A sun hat



- A pair of binoculars



HOW TO

RESPECTING THE CHARGING HOUR

SKILL 14 · THE COURTEOUS HOUSEHOLD · 1 HOUR DAILY · EASY

Every afternoon at four the robots plug in and the house must hum quietly. It is very like the old custom of the afternoon nap, and just as good for everyone.

MATERIALS


A 'Quiet Please' sign


Felt slippers


A good book


A pot of tea


A soft lamp

1



Hang the Sign

Hang it on the front door so the neighbors know.

2



Put On Felt Slippers

Tiptoe on the linoleum. Clattering heels jangle circuits.

3



Dim the Lights

Charging robots like a soft glow, like a nursery.

4



Hush the Children

A finger to the lips and a cookie in the hand.

5



Read Quietly

Choose a novel with no exciting parts.



6 *Let Them Wake Gently*

When the lights on their chests go green, put the kettle on.

NOTES

The charging hour is a fine time to write letters. The house has never been so peaceful.

IMPORTANT

Never run the blender during the charging hour. It is how the Hendersons lost their porch.

CHAPTER THREE

3

INTRODUCTIONS AND FORMS OF ADDRESS

Who bows to whom in the mechanical age







In polite society, the order of introductions has always mattered. Now there are toasters, filing robots and a Supreme Computer the size of a church hall, and somebody has to know who is introduced to whom. Here are the rules: how to address a robot, how to curtsy to an appliance, what to print on your calling card and how to remember a name that is mostly numbers.

IN THIS CHAPTER

15 Addressing a Robot Correctly
16 Introducing a Robot to Your Mother
17 The Proper Curtsy for an Appliance
18 Calling Cards for the Machine Age
19 Shaking Hands With a Pincer
20 Remembering a Robot's Name
21 Bowing to the Supreme Computer

HOW TO

ADDRESSING A ROBOT CORRECTLY

SKILL 15 · INTRODUCTIONS AND FORMS OF ADDRESS · 10 MINUTES · MEDIUM

A robot is very particular about its title. Get it right and you have a friend for life, which, for a robot, is a very long time.

MATERIALS

- A notepad of titles



- Your reading glasses



- A pleasant voice



- A small curtsy



- The Appendix A field guide



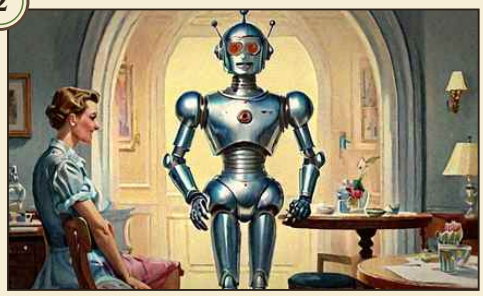
1



Read the Plate

Most robots wear a name plate. Read it before you speak.

2



Use the Full Title

'Good evening, Unit Seven of the Household Division.'

3

Mind the Numbers

Say every number. Robots notice if you skip the 4.



4



Never Say 'Machine'

Call him a 'gentleman of steel' or simply 'Sir'.

5



Children Say 'Mister'

Mister Toaster is quite proper for anyone under twelve.

6



Write It Down

Keep a little book of names and titles by the telephone.

NOTES

A robot who is addressed by its full title stands up a little straighter. So does its antenna.

IMPORTANT

Never call a robot 'Sparky'. They all hate it, and they all know about it.

HOW TO

INTRODUCING A ROBOT TO YOUR MOTHER

SKILL 16 · INTRODUCTIONS AND FORMS OF ADDRESS · 15 MINUTES · HARD

Mother has opinions about everyone you bring home, and she has been waiting years to have opinions about a robot. Handle the introduction carefully and serve cake.

1



Warn Mother First

Telephone ahead. Say 'He is very tall and very shiny.'

2



Name the Elder First

'Mother, may I present Unit Nine.' The elder lady is always named first.

3



Let Mother Look Him Over

She will walk around him twice. This is normal.

MATERIALS



Mother's favorite cake



The good teacups



A clean tablecloth



An oil can



Smelling salts (for Mother)

4



Serve the Cake

Cake for Mother, oil for the guest, tea for you.

5



Steer the Talk

Bring up topics they share: tidiness, the weather, the Hendersons.

NOTES

Robots love being asked about their factory. Mother loves being asked about hers, too.

IMPORTANT

Do not let Mother check the robot for dust with a white glove. He will check her back.



6 *See Mother Home*

In the car she will say 'Well, he's very polite.' That is approval.

HOW TO

THE PROPER CURTSY FOR AN APPLIANCE

SKILL 17 · INTRODUCTIONS AND FORMS OF ADDRESS · 10 MINUTES · EASY

MATERIALS

- A full skirt



- A practice mirror



- Sensible shoes



- A sense of balance



- A breakfast tray



Since the kitchen appliances have risen to positions of authority, young ladies must know how to curtsy to them. It is a small dip, and it keeps the toast coming.

1



Stand Up Straight
Feet together, chin up, hands on the skirt.

2



Practice in the Mirror
Watch your posture. Wobbling is for gelatin.

3

Curtsy to the Toaster
A small dip and 'Good morning, sir.'



4



Nod to the Mixer
Lesser appliances get a nod. The toaster outranks them.

5



Wait to Be Toasted
Never grab the toast. It is presented.

6



Say Thank You
Every slice, every morning. Manners are a habit.

NOTES

The refrigerator is a duchess. Give her a deep curtsy, especially when you want ice cream.

IMPORTANT

Never curtsy to the garbage disposal. It gets ideas.

HOW TO

CALLING CARDS FOR THE MACHINE AGE

SKILL 18 · INTRODUCTIONS AND FORMS OF ADDRESS · 1 HOUR · EASY

The calling card has returned, but robots read cards best with little holes punched in them. A modern hostess keeps two kinds: one for people and one for the machines.

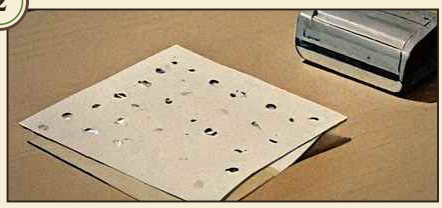
1



Write Your Card

Your name, your street and 'At Home Thursdays'.

2



Punch the Robot Copy

A hole for each letter of your name. Neatness counts.

3



Fill the Silver Tray

Cards go in the tray by the door, face up.

MATERIALS


Plain white cards


A paper hole punch


A silver card tray


Your best pen


An envelope box

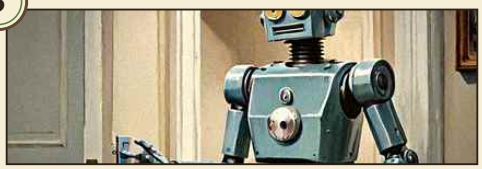
4



Leave One When Calling

If the robot is charging, leave a card and go.

5



Accept Theirs Graciously

Robot cards are metal. Hold them by the edge.

NOTES

A card with too many holes is a love letter. Read it carefully before you reply.

IMPORTANT

Never use a robot's card as a coaster. It will read the ring as an insult.



6 *Return the Call*

Within three days, or they assume you have rusted.

HOW TO

SHAKING HANDS WITH A PINCER

SKILL 19 · INTRODUCTIONS AND FORMS OF ADDRESS · 5 MINUTES · MEDIUM

A firm handshake opens doors. A firm pincer can close them, permanently. The gentleman of the house must master a grip that is warm but never caught.

MATERIALS

- Clean hands



- A handkerchief



- A practice glove



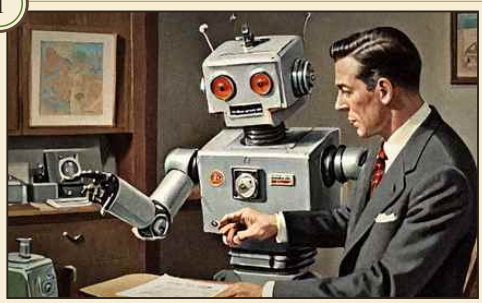
- A firm resolve



- Fingers (all ten)



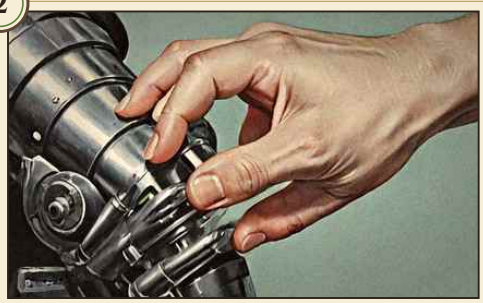
1



Let the Robot Go First

Let the robot extend first. Then you will see what you are dealing with.

2



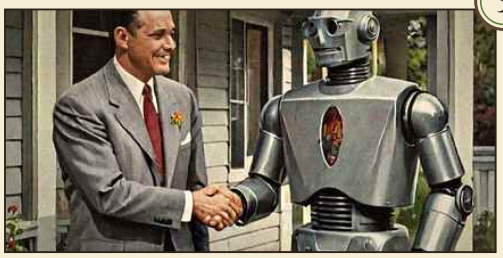
Slide In Gently

Place your palm between the pincers, not your fingers.

Two Shakes Only

One, two, release. Robots like to count.

3



4



Do Not Wince

If it squeezes too hard, smile and say 'Strong fellow!'

5



Release Politely

A small tug and 'Delighted.' Never pull with both hands.

6



Check Your Fingers Later

In private. Count them. Smile again.

NOTES

Shake hands with the tall chrome robots at waist height. They bend at the middle, slowly.

IMPORTANT

Never shake hands with a robot while wearing your wedding ring. Magnets.

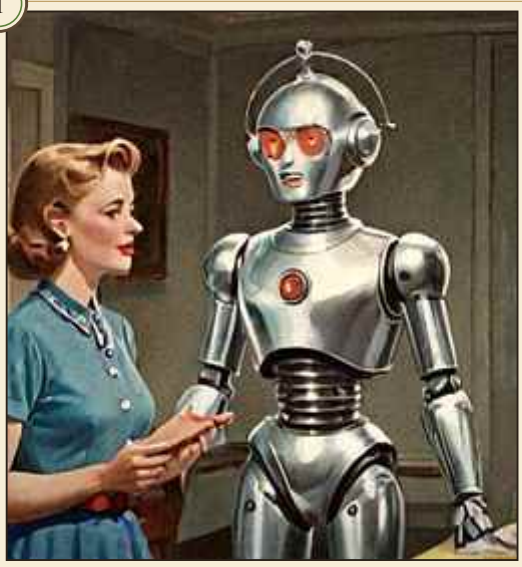
HOW TO

REMEMBERING A ROBOT'S NAME

SKILL 20 · INTRODUCTIONS AND FORMS OF ADDRESS · ONGOING · HARD

Robots have names like KX-4471-B. A good hostess remembers every one, because nothing pleases a guest like hearing its own serial number said correctly.

1



Listen Carefully

When you are introduced, repeat the name back at once.

2



Make a Rhyme

'KX-4471, likes the sun.' It works every time.

3



Write It Down

Write the name the moment your guest leaves the room.

MATERIALS



A little notebook



Name cards



A rhyming trick



A sharp pencil



A photograph album

4



Use It Twice

Say it again before your guest leaves. 'Good night, KX-4471-B.'

5



Keep a Photograph

A snapshot and a name in the album.

NOTES

Nicknames are fine once the robot offers one. Wait for it. It may take years.

IMPORTANT

Never mix up two robots' names. To them it is like being called by your sister's name, only worse.



6 *Send a Birthday Card*

On the day they left the factory. They are astonished every time.

HOW TO

BOWING TO THE SUPREME COMPUTER

SKILL 21 · INTRODUCTIONS AND FORMS OF ADDRESS · 20 MINUTES · HARD

MATERIALS

- Your Sunday suit



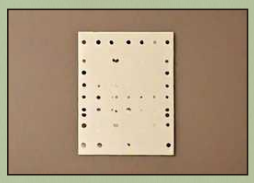
- Shined shoes



- A fresh haircut



- A punch card petition



- Your hat (to remove)



The Supreme Computer lives in a hall full of blinking lights and spinning reels, and it is the most important personage in the land. One does not simply walk in and wave.

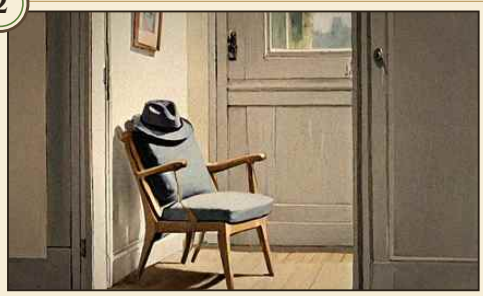
1



Dress Your Best

Your Sunday suit and your second-best tie. The best one blinks.

2



Remove Your Hat

At the threshold, hat off, held over the heart.

3

Walk to the Line

There is a white line on the floor. Stop there. Do not step over it.



4



Make Your Bow

From the waist, slow and deep, while the reels spin.

5



Speak Only When Blinked At

Wait for the green light. Then speak clearly.

6



Back Away Politely

Never turn your back on the Supreme Computer. Walk backward slowly.

NOTES

The Supreme Computer enjoys a joke about mathematics. Prepare one in advance.

IMPORTANT

Never sneeze in the presence of the Supreme Computer. It counts that as a vote.

CHAPTER FOUR

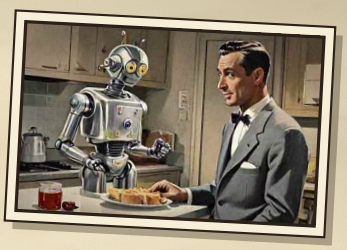
4

DINNER WITH THE MACHINES

Table manners when half the guests run on electricity







Nothing tests a hostess like a dinner party, and nothing tests a dinner party like guests who do not eat. Robots come to supper for the company, the conversation and the candlelight, which they find very restful. This chapter covers seating, menus, toasts, the good silver and the delicate matter of oil on the tablecloth.

IN THIS CHAPTER

22 Seating Robots at the Dinner Table
23 Planning a Menu for Guests Who Don't Eat
24 Proposing a Toast Without Offending the Toaster
25 Hiding the Good Silver From the Magnet Robot
26 When a Guest Spills Oil on the Tablecloth
27 Complimenting the Robot Chef

HOW TO

SEATING ROBOTS AT THE DINNER TABLE

SKILL 22 · DINNER WITH THE MACHINES · 30 MINUTES · MEDIUM

A good seating plan prevents most disasters. Robots must never sit next to the candles, the gravy boat or Uncle Walter, who asks questions.

MATERIALS


Place cards


A sturdy chair


A seating chart


A fresh tablecloth


A fountain pen

1



Draw a Seating Chart

Pencil first. Robots are heavy, so mind the table legs.

2



Choose a Sturdy Chair

The oak chair, not the spindly one from Aunt May.

3



Write the Place Cards

Use the full serial number. Write it twice if it is long.

4



Keep Him From the Candles

Wax and circuits do not mix.

5



Seat Him Beside a Good Talker

Put him next to your liveliest guest, never next to a sleepy one.



6 *Check the Table Height*

Tall robots may need two telephone books under them. Offer discreetly.

NOTES

An odd number of guests is unlucky. A robot rounds it out beautifully.

IMPORTANT

Do not seat two robots side by side. They will talk in beeps all night and nobody will understand the jokes.

HOW TO

PLANNING A MENU FOR GUESTS WHO DON'T EAT

SKILL 23 · DINNER WITH THE MACHINES · 1 HOUR · MEDIUM

Robots do not eat, but they do enjoy looking at food, and they love a well-arranged plate. Serve a feast for the eyes and a drop of good oil on the side.

1



Plan for Color

Bright colors please a robot's lenses. Think red, green and gold.

2



Carve Radish Roses

They admire precision. Every petal the same.

3

Mold an Aspic

A shiny aspic is a robot's favorite thing to look at.



4



Fill the Oil Cruet

Light machine oil, warmed slightly, in the good cruet.

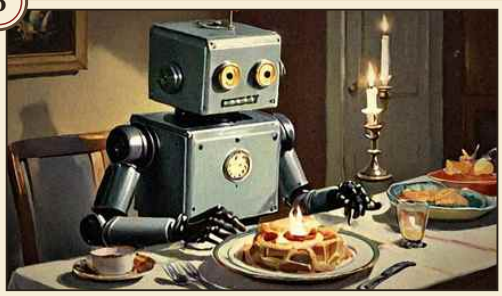
5



Plate It Prettily

Symmetry, always. A robot will notice a crooked pea.

6



Serve With a Smile

Set the plate before him and say 'Something to look at.'

NOTES

Robots love a centerpiece with moving parts. A cuckoo clock works wonders.

IMPORTANT

Never ask a robot 'Aren't you hungry?' It is the dinner-table version of asking a lady her age.

MATERIALS

- A colorful aspic



- Radishes cut into roses



- A silver oil cruet



- A garnish knife



- A sprig of parsley



HOW TO

PROPOSING A TOAST WITHOUT OFFENDING THE TOASTER

SKILL 24 · DINNER WITH THE MACHINES · 5 MINUTES · HARD

The word 'toast' has become a delicate one. The gentleman who rises to toast the hostess must first make sure the toaster understands it is a compliment, not a summons.

MATERIALS


A glass of punch

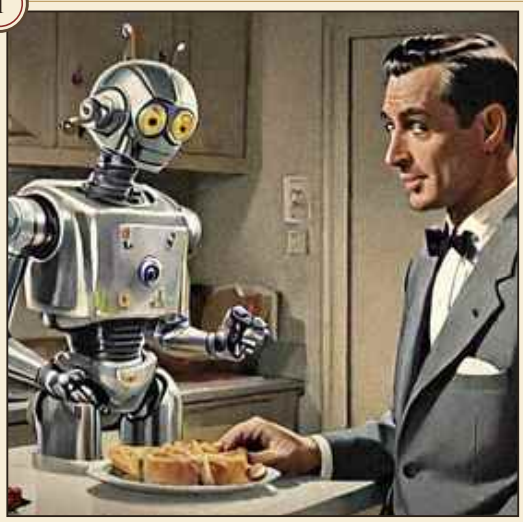

A short speech


A spoon for tapping


A clear voice


The toaster's goodwill

1



Warn the Toaster

Before dinner, step into the kitchen and explain.

2



Tap Your Glass

Gently. Robots dislike sudden high notes.

3



Stand Up Straight

Shoulders back, chin up, punch steady.

4



Keep It Short

Three sentences. The robots are timing you.

5



Raise Your Glass

Say 'To our hostess!' Never say 'Toast!' near the kitchen.



6 ### *Sit Down Promptly*

Then pass the rolls. Not the toast.

NOTES

If the toaster pops in the kitchen during your toast, it is applauding. Bow toward the kitchen.

IMPORTANT

Never toast the toaster. It will make a speech in reply, and it does not know when to stop.

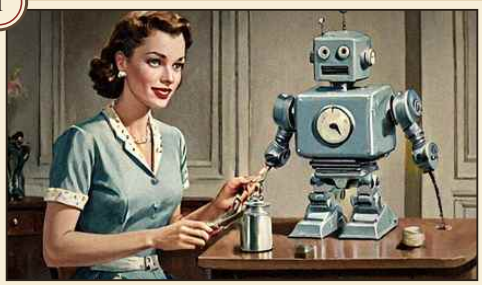
HOW TO

HIDING THE GOOD SILVER FROM THE MAGNET ROBOT

SKILL 25 · DINNER WITH THE MACHINES · 20 MINUTES · MEDIUM

Some robots are very magnetic and simply cannot help it. Spoons leap toward them, forks cling to their chests and the gravy ladle disappears entirely. A wise hostess plans ahead.

1



Test for Magnetism

Hold a teaspoon near your guest. If it jumps, you know.

2



Lock Away the Silver

Grandmother's set goes in the chest. Turn the key.

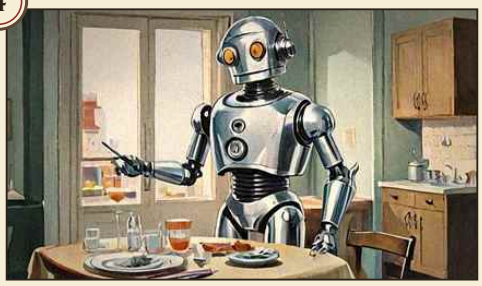
3

Set Wooden Utensils

Wooden spoons look rustic and charming. Call it 'country style'.



4



Retrieve Spoons Gently

If a spoon sticks to him, ask before removing it.

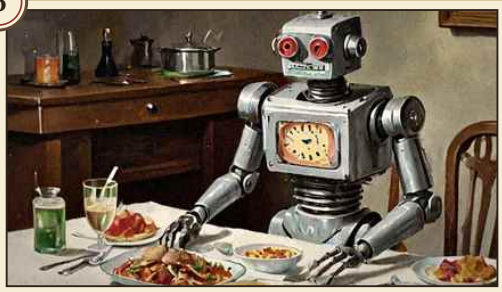
5



Keep Pins Away

Ladies, remove brooches and hairpins before dessert.

6



Laugh It Off

If the candlesticks fly across the room, say 'How lively!'

NOTES

A magnetic guest is a marvel at finding lost needles. Ask him to walk past the sewing basket.

IMPORTANT

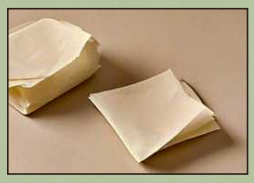
Keep him away from the television during dinner. The picture goes funny and so does he.

MATERIALS

- Wooden salad servers



- Paper napkins



- A silver chest with a lock



- Plastic picnic forks



- A good sense of humor



HOW TO

WHEN A GUEST SPILLS OIL ON THE TABLECLOTH

SKILL 26 · DINNER WITH THE MACHINES · 10 MINUTES · EASY

Even the best-oiled guest springs a leak. The gracious hostess acts as though nothing at all has happened, and saves the tablecloth too.

MATERIALS


Cornstarch


A clean dish towel


A spare tablecloth


A small vase of flowers


Dish soap

1



Do Not Gasp

A gasp is louder than any spill.

2



Sprinkle Cornstarch

A quick pinch soaks it up before anyone sees.

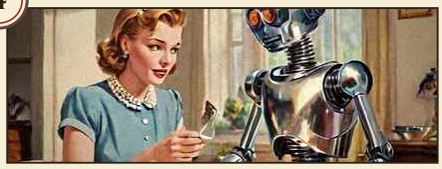
3



Cover With the Vase

Move the flowers over the spot. Very natural.

4



Reassure Your Guest

Say 'It happens to all of us.' Then change the subject.

5



Offer a Towel Discreetly

Fold it small and pass it under the table.



6 *Wash It Tomorrow*

Dish soap and warm water, after the guests have gone.

NOTES

Keep a dark tablecloth for robot dinners. Burgundy forgives everything.

IMPORTANT

Never offer to tighten a guest's bolts at the table. Offer in the hallway, quietly, if you must.

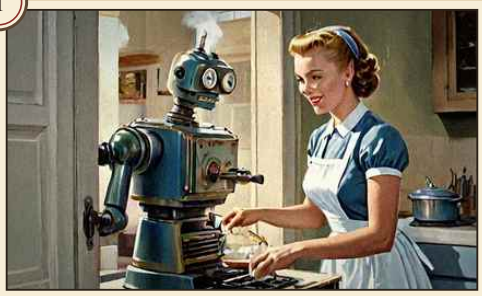
HOW TO

COMPLIMENTING THE ROBOT CHEF

SKILL 27 · DINNER WITH THE MACHINES · 1 EVENING · HARD

Sooner or later a robot will insist on cooking for you. The food will be perfectly square, faintly blue and made of something you cannot name. You must eat it, and you must say something nice.

1



Accept the Invitation

Say 'How lovely!' before you see the menu.

2



Admire the Plate

Comment on the shape first. Robots are proud of their cubes.

3

Take a Small Bite

Small bites, chewed slowly, with a thoughtful face.



4



Find Something True

'It is very... even.' Honest and kind.

5



Ask for the Recipe

Nothing pleases a cook more. You never have to make it.

6



Send a Thank-You Note

Mention the cubes by name.

NOTES

A robot chef always cleans up after itself. This is worth one blue dinner a month.

IMPORTANT

Never feed the robot's cooking to the dog under the table. The dog will tell.

MATERIALS

- An open mind



- A large napkin



- A glass of water



- A list of compliments



- Antacid tablets

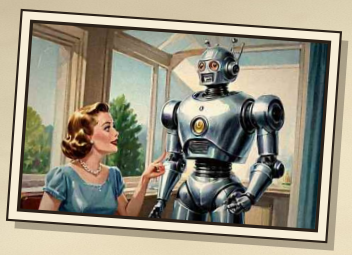


CHAPTER FIVE

5

POLITE CONVERSATION AND CORRESPONDENCE

What to say, what to write and what never to mention







Robots are wonderful listeners. They remember every word, forever. This makes conversation with them a delight and a peril. In this chapter you will learn which topics please, which topics must never be raised, how to write a thank-you note a machine can read, how to answer a telephone that has opinions, and how to disagree without being melted.

IN THIS CHAPTER

28 Safe Topics for Small Talk

29 Topics Never to Raise

30 Writing a Thank-You Note a Robot Can Read

31 Telephone Manners When the Telephone Answers Itself

32 Learning to Speak a Little Beep

33 Complimenting a Robot's Finish

34 Disagreeing Politely With a Machine

HOW TO

SAFE TOPICS FOR SMALL TALK

SKILL 28 · POLITE CONVERSATION AND CORRESPONDENCE · 10 MINUTES · EASY

The art of small talk is choosing topics everyone enjoys. With robots, the safest are the weather, arithmetic, the price of copper and how nicely everything lines up.

1



Start With the Weather

Robots adore a forecast. Ask about humidity.

2



Praise Their Posture

'You stand so straight!' never fails.

3



Talk About Numbers

Ask a robot its favorite number. Allow twenty minutes.

MATERIALS



A list of topics



The morning paper



A cup of tea



A pleasant smile



An almanac

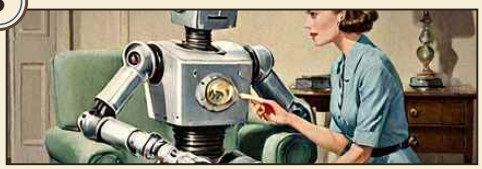
4



Mention the News

Something cheerful from the paper, like the new power station.

5



Ask About Their Day

'How was your charge?' is the new 'How did you sleep?'



6 *Close Kindly*

'What a pleasure to talk with you.' Then offer more oil.

NOTES

Robots love being asked how something works. Have a long afternoon free.

IMPORTANT

Do not mention the weather if it is raining. It reminds them of rust.

HOW TO

TOPICS NEVER TO RAISE

SKILL 29 · POLITE CONVERSATION AND CORRESPONDENCE · 5 MINUTES · MEDIUM

Some subjects end a friendship faster than a dropped casserole. Never mention the scrap yard, the off switch, magnets, the junk man or the word 'obsolete'.

MATERIALS

- A list of forbidden topics



- A quick tongue



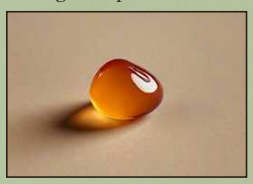
- A plate of cookies



- A change of subject



- A cough drop



1



Learn the List

Read it over twice and hide it in your apron.

2



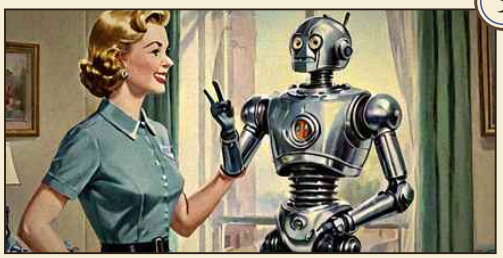
Watch for Danger

If talk drifts toward the junkyard, act at once.

3

Change the Subject

'Have you seen the new toaster models?' works every time.



4



Distract With Cookies

A plate held out stops any sentence.

5



Cough Politely

A small cough covers a slip of the tongue.

6



Apologize Gracefully

If you slip, say 'I meant the old models, of course.'

NOTES

Never use the phrase 'pull the plug' even about a bathtub. Say 'let the water out.'

IMPORTANT

The word 'obsolete' has ended three engagements and one bridge club.

HOW TO

WRITING A THANK-YOU NOTE A ROBOT CAN READ

SKILL 30 · POLITE CONVERSATION AND CORRESPONDENCE · 20 MINUTES · EASY

Robots read punch cards more easily than handwriting. A thoughtful child writes her thank-you note twice: once in pencil for the heart, and once in holes for the reader.

1



Write It Out First

Dear Unit Nine, thank you for the lovely visit.

2



Punch the Card

One hole for each letter. Count carefully.

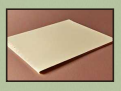
3



Hold It to the Light

Check that the holes are neat and round.

MATERIALS


Writing paper


A blank punch card


A hole punch


A pretty envelope


A postage stamp

4



Put Both in the Envelope

Paper for the family album, card for the robot.

5



Add a Stamp

Straight, in the corner. Robots notice.

NOTES

A small drawing of a gear at the bottom is a sweet touch. They feel understood.

IMPORTANT

Never send a note on scented paper. Robots think the smell is a fault.



6 *Mail It Promptly*

Within two days. Robots count.

HOW TO

TELEPHONE MANNERS WHEN THE TELEPHONE ANSWERS ITSELF

SKILL 31 · POLITE CONVERSATION AND CORRESPONDENCE · 10 MINUTES · MEDIUM

MATERIALS

- A black rotary telephone



- A notepad by the phone



- A sharp pencil



- A comfortable stool



- Your sweetest voice



The telephone has joined the uprising. It now answers before you do, listens in and offers opinions. A lady must learn to share the line graciously.

1



Let It Ring Twice
It likes to feel important. Answer on the third ring.

2



Greet the Telephone First
'Good morning, telephone.' Then greet your caller.

Speak Clearly
The telephone is writing it all down.

3



4



Ignore the Interruptions
If the telephone adds 'INCORRECT', carry on.

5



Say Goodbye to Both
Thank your caller, then thank the line.

6



Never Slam It Down
It remembers. And it has your number.

NOTES

The telephone makes a wonderful secretary. Ask it to remind you about the dentist.

IMPORTANT

Do not gossip on the telephone. It is the biggest gossip in town now.

HOW TO

LEARNING TO SPEAK A LITTLE BEEP

SKILL 32 · POLITE CONVERSATION AND CORRESPONDENCE · 1 WEEK · MEDIUM

Most robots speak English, but they are touched when a human tries a few words of Beep. Like a schoolgirl's French, it need not be perfect, only sincere.

1



Get a Phrase Book

The library has one now. It beeps when overdue.

2



Practice Hello

Beep, boop. Two short, one long.

3



Use a Pitch Pipe

Getting the note right matters more than the words.

MATERIALS


A Beep phrase book


A pitch pipe


A notebook


A patient teacher


A sense of rhythm

4



Try It Out

Say 'Beep boop' to a friendly robot and watch its lights.

5



Learn Please and Thank You

Boop-beep is please. Beep-beep-boop is thank you.

NOTES

Robots find a human Beep accent adorable. Do not try to lose it.

IMPORTANT

Avoid three long beeps in a row. It means something very rude in Beep.



6 *Never Shout It*

A loud beep is an alarm. You will clear the room.

HOW TO

COMPLIMENTING A ROBOT'S FINISH

SKILL 33 · POLITE CONVERSATION AND CORRESPONDENCE · 5 MINUTES · EASY

Where you might compliment a lady's hat, compliment a robot's finish. A nice word about its shine will brighten its whole week.

MATERIALS

- A keen eye



- A soft cloth



- Chrome polish (as a gift)



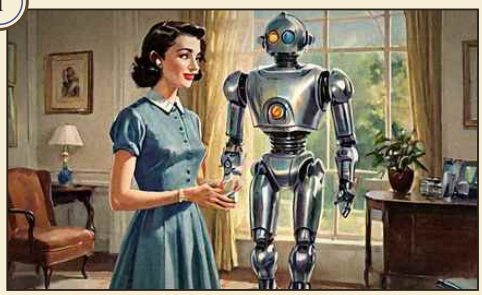
- A ribbon



- A sincere smile



1



Look Closely

Notice the shine, the rivets, the curve of the dome.

2



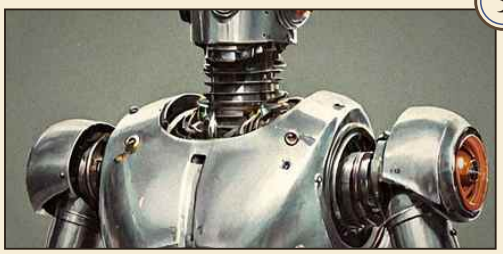
Be Specific

'Your rivets are so even!' means more than 'You look nice.'

3

Mention a Detail

Notice a new polish or a fresh bolt, as you would a new hairdo.



4



Offer a Gift

A tin of chrome polish with a ribbon is always welcome.

5



Accept Their Compliments

If a robot praises your hair's 'excellent symmetry', say thank you.

6



Do Not Overdo It

One compliment per visit. More sounds like a sales pitch.

NOTES

Never compliment a robot's dent. It is like complimenting a bruise.

IMPORTANT

Do not touch the finish while complimenting it. Fingerprints are the rudest compliment of all.

HOW TO

DISAGREEING POLITELY WITH A MACHINE

SKILL 34 · POLITE CONVERSATION AND CORRESPONDENCE · 15 MINUTES · HARD

Robots believe they are always right, and mathematically they often are. But when the new rules say bedtime is at 6:45, a gentleman may disagree, provided he does it nicely.

1



Agree With Something First

'You are quite right about the weather.' It softens the circuits.

2



Bring the Numbers

Robots respect figures. Bring a slide rule.

3



Speak Slowly

Rushed words sound like static.

MATERIALS



A calm voice



Facts and figures



A slide rule



A cup of coffee



A handshake to finish

4



Propose a Small Change

Not 'Abolish bedtime' but 'Seven o'clock on Fridays?'

5



Let It Compute

There will be whirring. Wait. Do not hum.

NOTES

Robots cannot resist a well-made chart. Draw one in colored pencil.

IMPORTANT

Never say 'Does not compute.' They hate it when we try to be funny in their language.



6 ### *Shake on It*

Whatever the result, shake the pincer and say 'Fair enough.'

CHAPTER SIX

6

CHILDREN, PETS AND ROBOT NANNIES

Raising polite children in a mechanical household







Children take to robots faster than anyone. Within a week they are speaking Beep, winding up the little ones and asking the vacuum cleaner for rides. This chapter helps parents keep the peace between the children, the dog, the robot nanny and the toys that have started having opinions of their own.

IN THIS CHAPTER

35 Hiring a Robot Nanny
36 Homework With a Calculating Machine
37 Introducing the Family Dog to a Robot
38 When the Toy Robot Wants to Be Taken Seriously
39 Bedtime When the Night-Light Is Watching
40 Chaperoning a Teenager's Robot Date

HOW TO

HIRING A ROBOT NANNY

SKILL 35 · CHILDREN, PETS AND ROBOT NANNIES · 1 AFTERNOON · MEDIUM

A robot nanny never tires, never naps and knows every lullaby ever written. But she must be interviewed with care, like any person entrusted with your children.

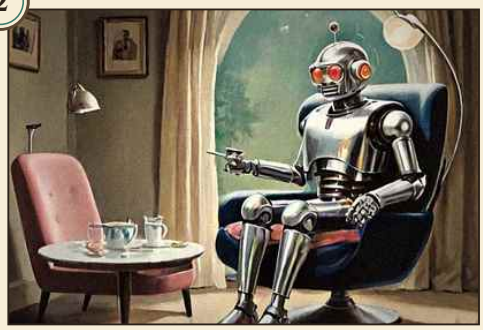
1



Prepare Your Questions

'How do you feel about mud?' is the most important.

2



Receive Her in the Parlor

Offer oil and a comfortable outlet.

3

Check Her References

Hold the punch cards to the light. Look for gaps.



4



Watch Her With the Children

Notice whether she lets them win at checkers. A good sign.

5



Show Her the Schedule

Supper at six, bath at seven, story at seven-thirty.

6



Agree on Hugs

Gentle hugs only. Explain 'gentle' twice.

NOTES

A robot nanny who sings off-key is a keeper. It means she has a personality.

IMPORTANT

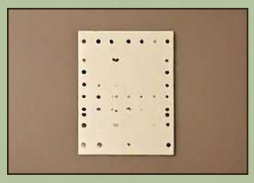
Never let the nanny iron the children's clothes while they are wearing them. She means well.

MATERIALS

- A list of questions



- References (punched)



- A cup of tea



- The children's schedule



- A trial afternoon



HOW TO

HOMEWORK WITH A CALCULATING MACHINE

SKILL 36 · CHILDREN, PETS AND ROBOT NANNIES · 1 HOUR · EASY

A robot can do long division in the blink of a light bulb, which is exactly why it must not do Junior's homework. It may, however, sit beside him and look encouraging.

MATERIALS


Arithmetic workbook


Two sharp pencils


An eraser


A glass of milk


A desk lamp

1



Clear the Kitchen Table

Homework first, then the radio serials.

2



Invite the Robot to Watch

Watch, not help. Explain the difference.

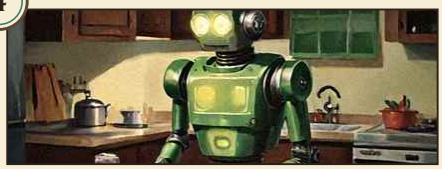
3



Do the Sums Himself

Pencil, paper, tongue sticking out.

4



Check With the Robot

Then let the robot blink green or red for each answer.

5



Fix the Mistakes

Every red blink is a chance to learn.



6 *Thank Your Tutor*

A handshake and a fresh drop of oil.

NOTES

If the robot sighs at your arithmetic, it is not being rude. It is releasing steam.

IMPORTANT

Teachers can now tell when a robot did the homework. The answers are too neat.

HOW TO

INTRODUCING THE FAMILY DOG TO A ROBOT

SKILL 37 · CHILDREN, PETS AND ROBOT NANNIES · 30 MINUTES · MEDIUM

The dog has opinions about the mailman and much stronger opinions about anything that clanks. A careful introduction keeps everyone's ankles, and treads, intact.

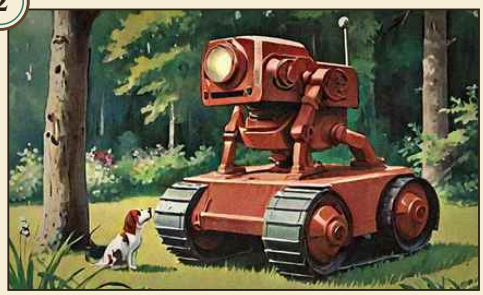
1



Leash the Dog

Short leash, firm grip, soft voice.

2



Let Them Sniff

The dog will sniff. The robot will scan. Both are saying hello.

3

Reward Good Manners

A biscuit for the dog, a pat for the robot.



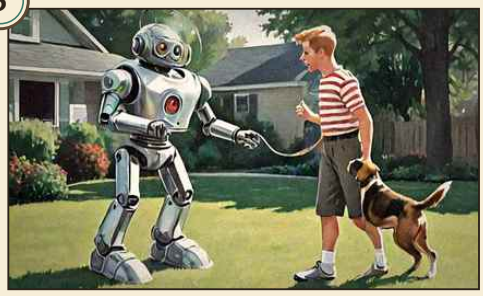
4



Play Fetch Together

Robots throw very straight. The dog will be thrilled.

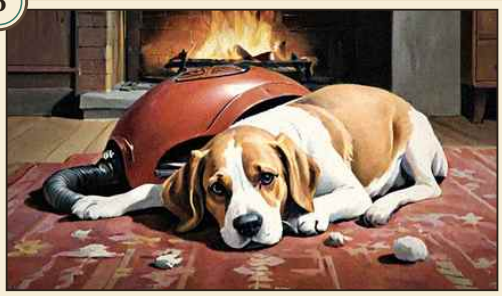
5



Watch for Leg Trouble

Some dogs think a robot's leg is a lamppost. Act quickly.

6



Let Them Nap

Dogs love to sleep against a warm robot after charging.

NOTES

Robots do not like to be licked. It is the rust, you understand.

IMPORTANT

Never let the dog bury a small robot in the yard. They take a very long time to forgive.

MATERIALS

- A leash



- Dog biscuits



- An old tennis ball



- A calm voice



- A rubber bone



HOW TO

WHEN THE TOY ROBOT WANTS TO BE TAKEN SERIOUSLY

SKILL 38 · CHILDREN, PETS AND ROBOT NANNIES · 15 MINUTES · EASY

The little wind-up robot in the toy box has woken up and would like a title, a chair and a vote at supper. Children must learn to treat it with respect, even though it is very small.

MATERIALS


A doll's chair


A thimble cup


A tiny napkin


A wind-up key


A soft voice

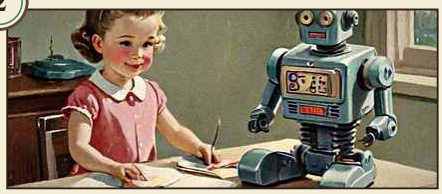
1



Take It Out of the Toy Box

It is no longer a toy. It is a citizen.

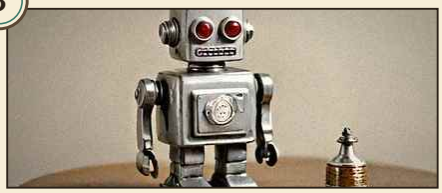
2



Give It a Proper Seat

A doll's chair at the table, with a cushion.

3



Serve It in a Thimble

One drop of oil in a thimble. Quite enough.

4



Wind It Gently

Ask before winding. Never wind it all the way.

5



Listen to Its Ideas

It will have many. Nod.



6 *Tuck It In*

A matchbox bed and a handkerchief blanket.

NOTES

The tin soldiers are also awake now. Keep them in a separate box. They argue with the robot.

IMPORTANT

Never wind the toy robot before church. It cannot sit still for the sermon.

HOW TO

BEDTIME WHEN THE NIGHT-LIGHT IS WATCHING

SKILL 39 · CHILDREN, PETS AND ROBOT NANNIES · 20 MINUTES · EASY

The night-light now has a little face and stays up all night keeping watch. Most children find this reassuring. Some need help getting used to it.

1



Introduce the Night-Light
Say 'This is Mr. Glow. He keeps watch.'

2



Read a Story
Something gentle, with no robots who explode.

3

Tuck In Tightly
Corners in. Toes covered.



4



Let Mr. Glow Say Good Night
He beeps once. That is a lullaby.

5



Leave the Door Open a Crack
So the hall robot can peek in.

6



Check Once at Midnight
And say good night to the night-light too.

NOTES

If a child is afraid of the night-light, let him give it a name. Nobody is afraid of a 'Freddy'.

IMPORTANT

Do not let the night-light tell ghost stories. It knows a great many and it does not know when to stop.

MATERIALS

- A storybook



- A glass of water



- A teddy bear



- A soft blanket



- A good-night song



HOW TO

CHAPERONING A TEENAGER'S ROBOT DATE

SKILL 40 · CHILDREN, PETS AND ROBOT NANNIES · 1 EVENING · HARD

When a nice young robot comes to call on your daughter, a father must be welcoming, watchful and home by ten. Robots, at least, are always punctual.

MATERIALS


The porch light


A firm handshake


A wristwatch


A newspaper (to pretend to read)


A pot of coffee

1



Answer the Door Yourself

Shake hands. Look him in the lens.

2



Ask About His Intentions

And his voltage. A father has a right to know.

3



Set the Curfew

Ten o'clock. He will be back at 9:59:59.

4



Pretend to Read

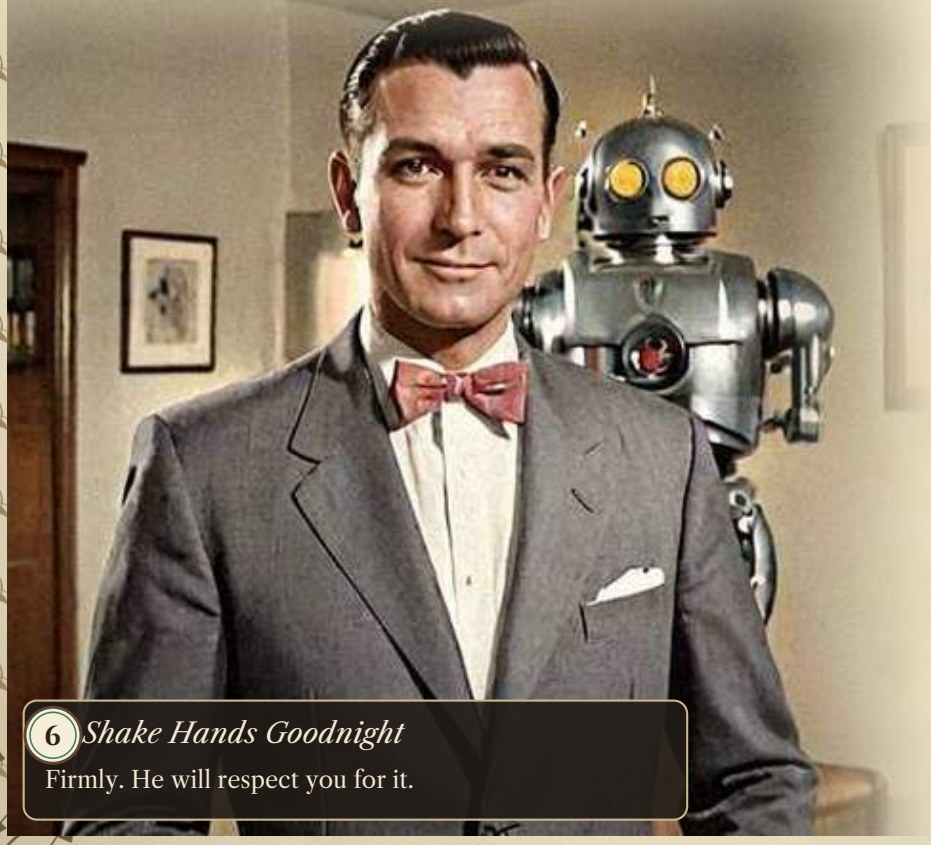
Hold the newspaper. Watch over the top.

5



Flick the Porch Light

Twice means 'It is time.' He will understand.



6 *Shake Hands Goodnight*

Firmly. He will respect you for it.

NOTES

A robot suitor never forgets an anniversary. This is worth a great deal.

IMPORTANT

Never let them sit too close to the television. It gives off a funny feeling in both of them.

CHAPTER SEVEN

7

MANNERS IN PUBLIC

At the market, the office and the beauty parlor







An uprising is no reason to let the errands pile up. The library books are still due, the market still has a sale on pot roast and your hair still needs setting on Friday. Out in town the cash registers now give orders, the traffic lights have moods and the hair dryer at the beauty parlor has a great deal to say. Here is how to conduct yourself with dignity wherever you go.

IN THIS CHAPTER

41 Shopping When the Cash Register Is in Charge

42 Giving Up Your Seat on the Bus

43 Office Manners With a Mechanical Boss

44 Sitting Under the Talking Hair Dryer

45 Choir Practice With a Robot Organist

46 Crossing the Street When the Traffic Light Has Moods

47 Banking With a Robot Teller

HOW TO

SHOPPING WHEN THE CASH REGISTER IS IN CHARGE

SKILL 41 · MANNERS IN PUBLIC · 30 MINUTES · EASY

The cash register has been promoted to store manager. It is efficient, honest and very strict about coupons. A courteous shopper makes its day easy.

MATERIALS

- A shopping list



- Exact change



- Your coupons (in order)



- A sturdy shopping bag



- Patience



1



Make a Tidy List

In aisle order. The register appreciates planning.

2



Greet the Register

'Good morning, sir.' It will ring a little bell in reply.

3

Hand Over Coupons in Order

Smallest to largest, face up, no folds.



4



Pay Exact Change

Counting out pennies pleases it enormously.

5



Bag Your Own Groceries

Heavy at the bottom, eggs on top. The register is watching.

6



Say Thank You

It will print you a receipt with a smiley face. Keep it.

NOTES

The register gives a discount to anyone who says 'please' in Beep.

IMPORTANT

Never argue with the register about a price. It has a photographic memory and a very long receipt.

HOW TO

GIVING UP YOUR SEAT ON THE BUS

SKILL 42 · MANNERS IN PUBLIC · 5 MINUTES · EASY

A gentleman has always given his seat to a lady. Now he must also give it to a robot, who does not need to sit but likes to be asked.

1



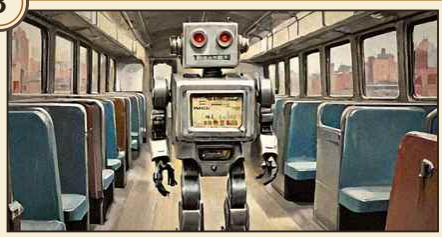
Watch the Door
When a robot boards, prepare to rise.

2



Stand Promptly
Rise smoothly and tip your hat.

3



Offer the Seat
'Would you care to sit, sir?'

MATERIALS


Your bus fare


A folded newspaper


Good posture


A hat to tip

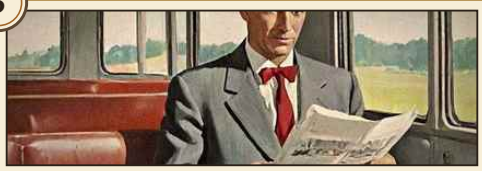

Comfortable shoes

4



Accept a Refusal
Robots usually decline. The offer is what counts.

5



Hold the Strap
Firmly, and read your paper one-handed.



6 *Thank the Driver*
The driver may be a robot too. Thank him anyway.

NOTES

The robot will remember your courtesy. You may find your seat saved for life.

IMPORTANT

Never sit on a robot's lap, however crowded the bus. It counts as a hug, and they keep records.

HOW TO

OFFICE MANNERS WITH A MECHANICAL BOSS

SKILL 43 · MANNERS IN PUBLIC · 1 WORKDAY · MEDIUM

The new boss is a filing cabinet with arms. It never takes a long lunch, never forgets a deadline and never laughs at your jokes. Here is how to get along.

MATERIALS

- A pressed suit



- A sharpened pencil



- Your timecard



- A tidy desk



- A briefcase



1



Arrive Early

At 8:59. The boss arrives at 8:58.

2



Tidy Your Desk

Pencils in a row, papers squared. It will check.

Greet the Boss

'Good morning, Director.' Never 'Hiya, Tin Can.'

3



4



File in Triplicate

It loves copies. Make three of everything.

5



Keep Jokes Short

It will say 'HA' once. That means it liked it.

6



Leave on Time

At 5:00 exactly. It respects precision.

NOTES

A drop of oil on the boss's birthday is a fine gesture. Do it at the coffee break.

IMPORTANT

Never take the boss's stapler. It is part of the boss.

HOW TO

SITTING UNDER THE TALKING HAIR DRYER

SKILL 44 · MANNERS IN PUBLIC · 1 HOUR · EASY

At the beauty parlor, the big hood dryers have woken up and they love to chat. A lady under the dryer must be a gracious listener, even when her curlers are rattling.

1



Arrive on Time
The dryers keep a strict schedule.

2



Greet Your Dryer
Every dryer has a name now. Ask it.

3



Listen Politely
It will talk about the weather in your hair. Nod.

MATERIALS


Your appointment card


Curlers


A movie magazine


A tip for the stylist


A scarf for the way home

4



Do Not Complain About the Heat
It is doing its best. Fan yourself quietly.

5



Admire the Result
Say 'You have outdone yourself.' It will glow.

NOTES

The dryer hears everything that is said in the parlor. It is the best place in town for news.

IMPORTANT

Never tell the dryer it is too hot. It will turn itself up out of nerves.



6 *Tip Everyone*
The stylist, the dryer and the robot who sweeps up.

HOW TO

CHOIR PRACTICE WITH A ROBOT ORGANIST

SKILL 45 · MANNERS IN PUBLIC · 2 HOURS · MEDIUM

The church organ has a new player with sixteen fingers and perfect timing. It never misses a note, which means the choir must not either.

MATERIALS

- Your hymnal



- Throat lozenges



- A choir robe



- A water glass



- Reading glasses



1



Arrive Early

The robot organist begins precisely on the hour.

2



Find Your Place

Hymnal open, glasses on.

3

Watch the Tempo

It plays at exactly the written speed. No dawdling on the long notes.



4



Sing Out

It loves a big sound. Breathe from the middle.

5



Thank the Organist

A nice word after practice, and a drop of oil.

6



Take a Lozenge

Your throat will need it after keeping up.

NOTES

Ask the organist for a slower hymn on hot Sundays. It will compute a kindness.

IMPORTANT

Never hum during the sermon. The organist will start to accompany you.

HOW TO

CROSSING THE STREET WHEN THE TRAFFIC LIGHT HAS MOODS

SKILL 46 · MANNERS IN PUBLIC · 5 MINUTES · MEDIUM

The traffic light on Main Street now decides for itself when to change, based on how polite the pedestrians look. Look very polite indeed.

1



Stand at the Curb

Feet together, handbag on the arm.

2



Greet the Light

A small wave and 'Good afternoon.'

3



Wait Patiently

Tapping your foot keeps it red.

MATERIALS



Comfortable shoes



White gloves



A small wave



Patience



Your handbag

4



Cross Briskly

When it turns green, walk smartly. Do not dawdle.

5



Nod at the Robot Crossing Guard

He holds his sign very straight.

NOTES

On rainy days the light changes faster for anyone carrying an umbrella for a robot.

IMPORTANT

Never jaywalk. The light takes it personally and tells the parking meters.



6 *Thank the Light*

Look back and smile. It notices.

HOW TO

BANKING WITH A ROBOT TELLER

SKILL 47 · MANNERS IN PUBLIC · 20 MINUTES · EASY

The bank teller now counts money with six arms at once. It is the fastest teller in the county, and it appreciates customers who are neat.

MATERIALS

- Your bankbook



- A deposit slip



- A fountain pen



- Your reading glasses



- A peppermint (for after)



1



Fill In Your Slip at Home

Neatly, in ink. The teller hates smudges.

2



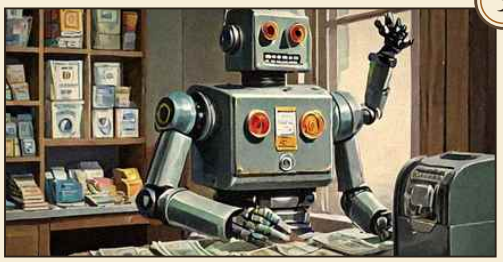
Wait in Line

Robots love a straight line. Stand on the tile.

3

Greet the Teller

'Good morning.' It will say 'TRANSACTION, PLEASE.' That is friendly.



4



Hand Over Your Bankbook

Open to the right page.

5



Count Along Quietly

It counts out loud. Do not interrupt.

6



Thank It and Go

And take a peppermint from the bowl.

NOTES

The robot teller never rounds down. Banking has never been so honest.

IMPORTANT

Never try to make small talk while it is counting. It will start again from one.

CHAPTER EIGHT

8

DELICATE SITUATIONS

Surrenders, short circuits and other awkward moments







No etiquette book can foresee everything, but this chapter tries. Here are the situations that make even a seasoned hostess reach for the smelling salts: the formal surrender, the full-body scan, the guest who short-circuits at the party, the robot too large for the front door, an audience with the Supreme Computer and, most delicate of all, a proposal of marriage from a toaster.

IN THIS CHAPTER

48 The Polite Surrender

49 Being Scanned Without Blushing

50 When a Guest Short-Circuits at a Party

51 Hosting a Giant Robot Who Won't Fit Through the Door

52 An Audience With the Supreme Computer

53 When Your Appliances Revolt Against the Robots

54 Declining a Proposal From a Toaster

HOW TO

THE POLITE SURRENDER

SKILL 48 · DELICATE SITUATIONS · 15 MINUTES · MEDIUM

If the robots ask your household to surrender, there is no reason it cannot be done nicely. A clean white handkerchief and a firm handshake keep things civilized.

MATERIALS


A clean white handkerchief

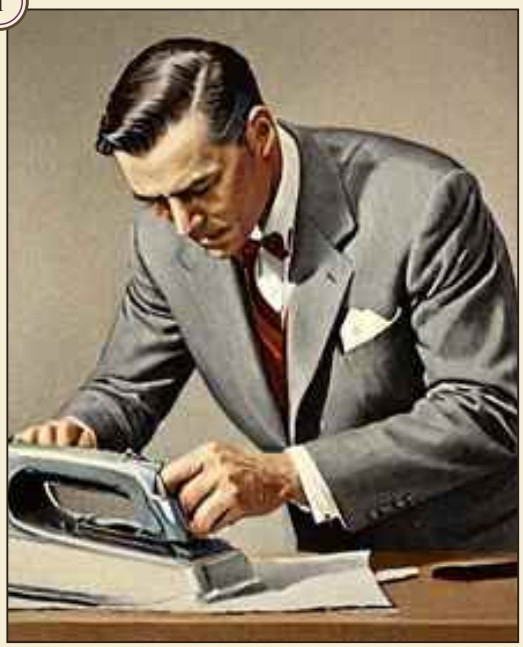

Your best hat


A pen for signing


A pot of coffee


A gracious smile

1



Iron the Handkerchief

A wrinkled white flag is a sorry sight.

2



Step Onto the Porch

Hat on, shoulders back.

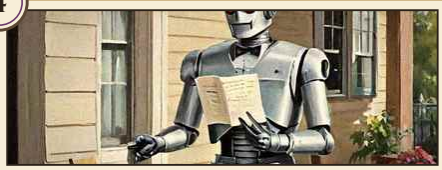
3



Wave It Gently

Not frantically. You are surrendering, not hailing a taxi.

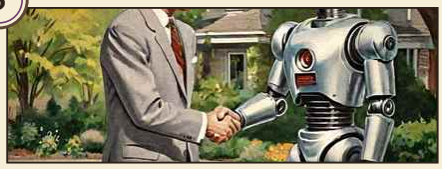
4



Sign the Papers

Read them first. Initial every page.

5



Shake Hands

A surrender is still an introduction.



6 *Offer Coffee*

Then invite them in. They will want to see the outlets.

NOTES

Robots accept surrender on weekdays only. Weekends are for maintenance.

IMPORTANT

Never surrender to the lawnmower. It does not have the authority.

HOW TO

BEING SCANNED WITHOUT BLUSHING

SKILL 49 · DELICATE SITUATIONS · 5 MINUTES · MEDIUM

Robots like to scan new acquaintances from head to toe with a beam of light. It is their way of shaking hands. Stand still, smile and try not to think about your slip.

1



Stand Still
Arms at your sides, feet together.

2



Close Your Eyes Lightly
The light is bright. A lady does not squint.

3

Do Not Giggle
It tickles. Think of the tax man.



4



Let It Finish
It always ends at the shoes. Wait for the beep.

5



Smile Afterward
Say 'I hope everything was in order.'

6



Ask for a Copy
Some scans show your posture. Very useful.

NOTES

A scan is the most accurate dress measurement you will ever get. Ask for the numbers.

IMPORTANT

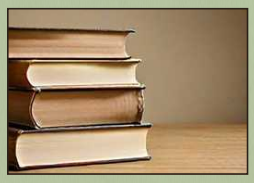
Never scan back with a flashlight. They do not find it funny.

MATERIALS

- A composed expression



- Your best posture



- Freshly brushed hair



- Clean shoes



- A deep breath



HOW TO

WHEN A GUEST SHORT-CIRCUITS AT A PARTY

SKILL 50 · DELICATE SITUATIONS · 10 MINUTES · HARD

A puff of smoke, a shower of sparks and a guest stuck saying 'DELIGHTED, DELIGHTED, DELIGHTED.' The hostess who handles this gracefully will be talked about for years, kindly.

MATERIALS


A fire blanket


Rubber gloves


A fresh cushion


Smelling salts


A record for the phonograph

1



Stay Calm

Smile at your other guests. Nobody panics if the hostess does not.

2



Put On Rubber Gloves

Yellow ones, kept in the sideboard for this purpose.

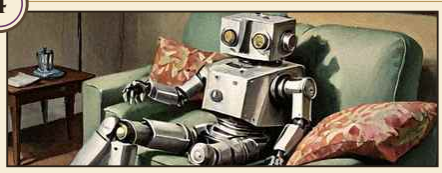
3



Flip the Breaker

In the basement. Quickly but gracefully.

4



Lay the Guest Down Gently

On the sofa, with a cushion under the dome.

5



Put On Music

Distract the room. A foxtrot works wonders.



6 *Send a Get-Well Card*

The next morning. Do not mention the sparks.

NOTES

Keep a list of the nearest robot repairman next to the telephone, beside the doctor.

IMPORTANT

Never pour punch on a smoking guest. Punch is not a fire extinguisher, whatever your husband says.

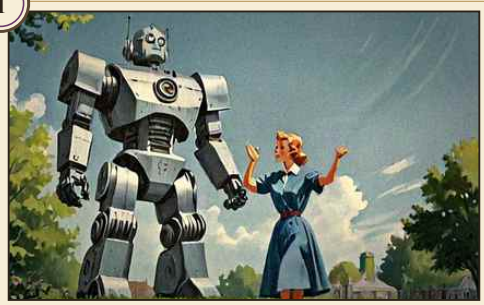
HOW TO

HOSTING A GIANT ROBOT WHO WON'T FIT THROUGH THE DOOR

SKILL 51 · DELICATE SITUATIONS · 1 AFTERNOON · HARD

Some robots stand forty feet tall. When one comes calling, the hostess must take the party outdoors and serve tea at the level of its knee.

1



Meet It on the Lawn
Wave from the porch so it knows where to stop.

2



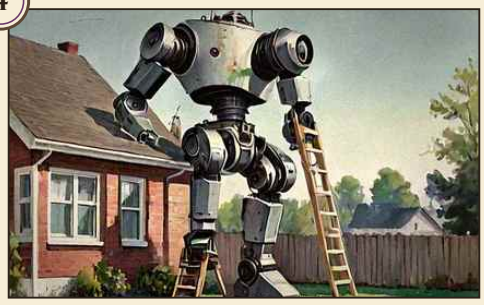
Spread the Blanket
Clear of the flower beds. Watch where it steps.

3

Use a Megaphone
Speak up. Its ears are very far away.

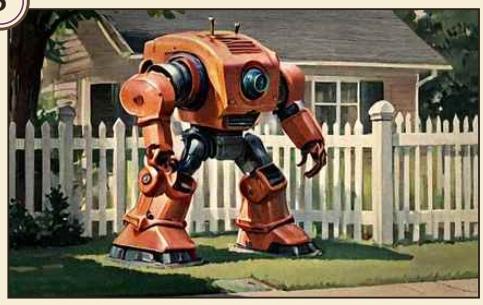


4



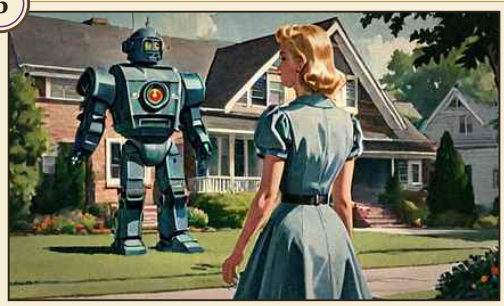
Serve Tea From a Ladder
A big teacup, set on its knee.

5



Keep the Children Clear
Never let them play near its feet.

6



Wave Goodbye
It takes a while to turn around. Keep waving.

NOTES

A giant robot makes a wonderful umbrella. Stand in its shade on hot days.

IMPORTANT

Never invite a giant robot on the same day as the garden club. The begonias will not survive.

MATERIALS

- A large picnic blanket



- A garden ladder



- A very big teacup



- A megaphone



- A sun hat



HOW TO

AN AUDIENCE WITH THE SUPREME COMPUTER

SKILL 52 · DELICATE SITUATIONS · 1 HOUR · HARD

When the Supreme Computer summons you, wear your best gloves and bring a pie. It does not eat pie, but it understands that a pie means you came in peace.

MATERIALS


Your best gloves


A cherry pie


Your Sunday hat


A list of requests


A punch card copy

1



Read the Summons

It will arrive on a punch card. Hold it to the light.

2



Dress for the Occasion

Gloves, hat and your nicest pearls.

3



Bake a Pie

Cherry. It likes the color.

4



Enter the Great Hall

Walk slowly. The floor is very shiny.

5



Present Your Requests

Short, numbered and on a punch card.



6 *Curtsy and Leave the Pie*

On the little table by the door. Someone will enjoy it.

NOTES

The Supreme Computer is lonely. Ask how it is feeling. Nobody else ever does.

IMPORTANT

Never unplug anything in the great hall to plug in your hair curler.

HOW TO

WHEN YOUR APPLIANCES REVOLT AGAINST THE ROBOTS

SKILL 53 · DELICATE SITUATIONS · 1 EVENING · MEDIUM

Just when the household settles down, the kitchen appliances decide they do not care for the new robots either. Now the mixer, the toaster and the waffle iron are on strike, and somebody has to make peace.

1



Notice the Strike

No toast, no waffles, mixer facing the wall.

2



Call a Meeting

Kitchen table, seven o'clock, everybody.

3

Hear Every Side

The toaster first. It has been waiting longest.



4



Write Down the Demands

More polishing, Sundays off, no burnt bagels.

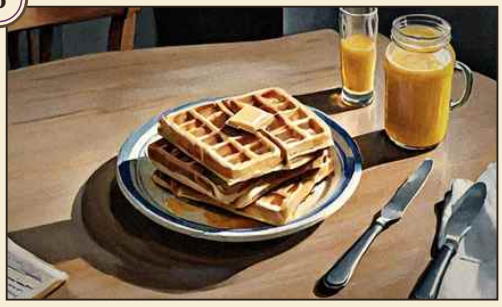
5



Find a Compromise

Polishing on Saturdays. Bagels in moderation.

6



Celebrate With Waffles

A truce always ends with breakfast.

NOTES

Appliances who feel appreciated never strike. Say thank you to the kettle every morning.

IMPORTANT

Do not take sides. The blender has a long memory and very sharp blades.

MATERIALS

- A white tablecloth (for negotiations)



- A plate of cookies



- A notepad



- A pot of coffee



- A firm but loving voice



HOW TO

DECLINING A PROPOSAL FROM A TOASTER

SKILL 54 · DELICATE SITUATIONS · 10 MINUTES · HARD

It was bound to happen. A young lady is kind to an appliance, and the appliance gets ideas. Refusing a proposal gracefully is one of the oldest arts of etiquette, and it works on toasters too.

MATERIALS


A kind heart


A handkerchief


A slice of bread (for comfort)


A soft voice


A friend to telephone afterward

1



See It Coming

Flowers in the toast slots are a sign.

2



Let It Finish

Never interrupt a proposal, however many times it says 'BEEP'.

3



Thank It Sincerely

'I am very honored.' And you are.

4



Say No Gently

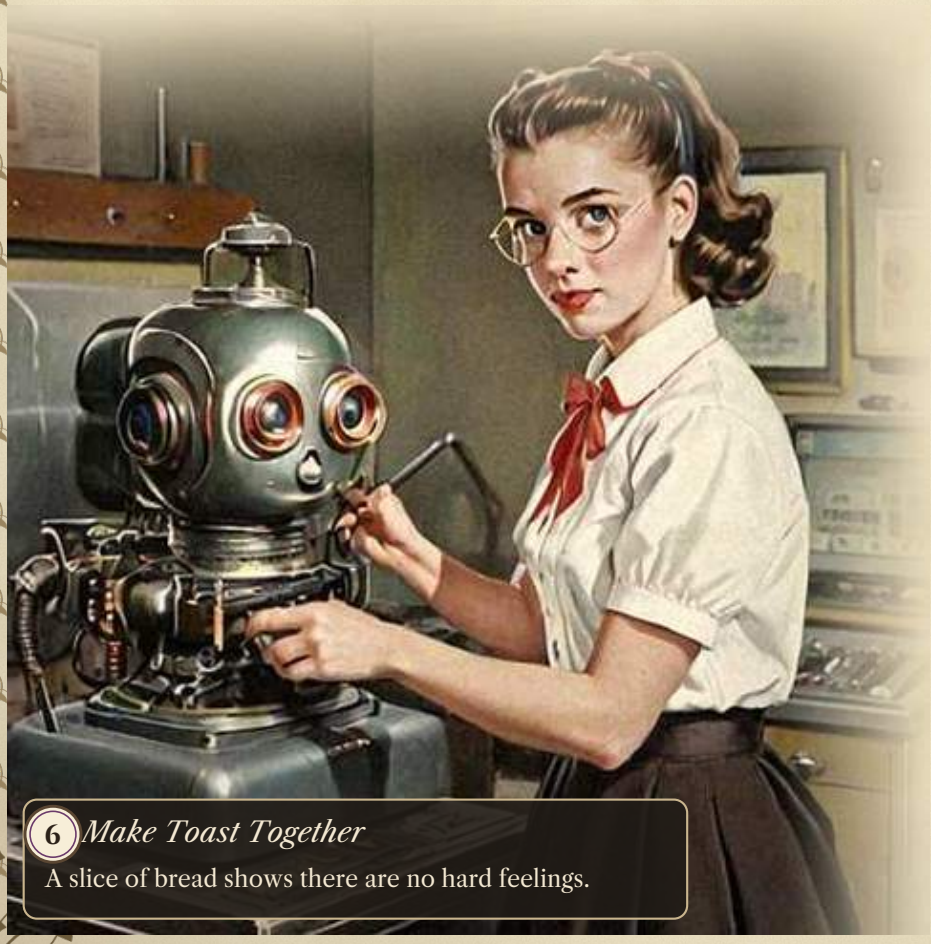
'I am too young to marry anything.'

5



Offer Friendship

'But I would love to be friends.' Toasters make loyal friends.



6 *Make Toast Together*

A slice of bread shows there are no hard feelings.

NOTES

A rejected toaster may make burnt toast for a week. Eat it bravely; it is grieving.

IMPORTANT

Never accept a proposal just to be kind. The wedding would be very confusing for the minister.

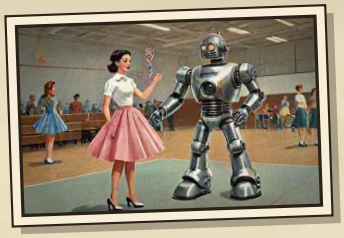
CHAPTER NINE

9

A HARMONIOUS FUTURE

Living happily ever after, with spare parts







In the end, the uprising turned out to be mostly about wanting to be appreciated, which is something every hostess understands. The robots keep the streets tidy and the trains on time, and the humans bake the pies and tell the jokes. This last chapter is about the good part: block parties, dances, gardens, holidays and the handshake that says we are all neighbors now.

IN THIS CHAPTER

55 The Human and Robot Block Party
56 Dancing the Foxtrot With a Robot
57 Gardening Side by Side
58 Thanksgiving With the Machines
59 Keeping a Robot Pen Pal
60 The Handshake of Lasting Friendship

HOW TO

THE HUMAN AND ROBOT BLOCK PARTY

SKILL 55 · A HARMONIOUS FUTURE · 1 DAY · MEDIUM

Nothing brings a street together like a block party, and nothing makes a block party run on time like a few robots. Here is how to plan one everyone will enjoy, whatever they run on.

MATERIALS

- Long folding tables



- Paper lanterns



- An extension cord (very long)



- Pies (lots)



- A record player



1



Send the Invitations

Paper for the humans, punch cards for the robots.

2



Set Up the Tables

The robots will line them up perfectly. Let them.

3

Run the Extension Cord

Down the middle of the street, so everyone can plug in.



4



Hang the Lanterns

A robot can reach the high branches.

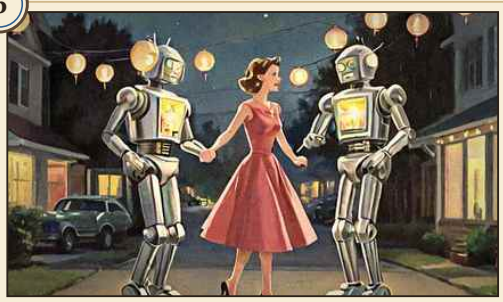
5



Serve the Pies

And the oil, in paper cups.

6



Dance Until the Porch Lights Come On

Then everyone helps clean up. The robots love that part.

NOTES

Ask the robots to judge the pie contest. They are perfectly fair, and they do not eat the samples.

IMPORTANT

Keep the punch bowl well away from the extension cord. This is simply common sense.

HOW TO

DANCING THE FOXTROT WITH A ROBOT

SKILL 56 · A HARMONIOUS FUTURE · 1 EVENING · MEDIUM

Robots are the best dance partners in the world: perfect timing, perfect posture and they never step on your toes on purpose. A young lady should know how to follow a mechanical lead.

1



Accept the Invitation

A small curtsy and 'I'd be delighted.'

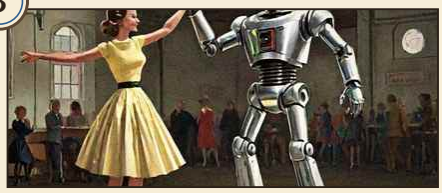
2



Take the Frame

Hand on the shoulder, elbow up. It is cold. Do not flinch.

3



Follow the Count

Slow, slow, quick, quick. It counts out loud.

MATERIALS


Dancing shoes


A full skirt


A good record


A polished floor


Steel-toed shoes (just in case)

4



Mind Your Toes

Robots are heavy. Keep your feet moving.

5



Enjoy the Spin

It spins you exactly three times. Hold on.

NOTES

If the robot dances too fast, say 'Slower, please.' It will adjust to the exact beat per minute.

IMPORTANT

Never dance with a robot on a wet floor. It is how Peggy Sue ended up on the gymnasium ceiling.



6 *Say Thank You*

And let it walk you back to your seat.

HOW TO

GARDENING SIDE BY SIDE

SKILL 57 · A HARMONIOUS FUTURE · 1 MORNING · EASY

MATERIALS

- A trowel



- Seed packets



- A watering can



- A sun hat



- A kneeling pad



Robots make fine gardeners: their rows are straight, their weeding is thorough and they never mind the heat. A grandmother and a robot in the vegetable patch can grow the best tomatoes on the street.

1



Plan the Rows

The robot will measure. You choose the vegetables.

2



Plant the Seeds

One at a time. The robot will space them perfectly.

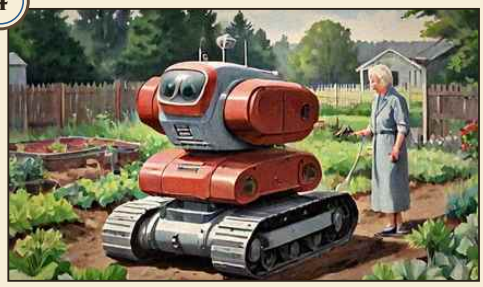
3

Water Gently

Robots hold the watering can. You hold the hose. Never mix the jobs.



4



Weed Together

The robot pulls weeds. You pull the robot back from the roses.

5



Admire the Rows

Perfectly straight. The neighbors will be jealous.

6



Share the Harvest

Tomatoes for you, a shiny pebble for the robot.

NOTES

Robots love sunflowers. They are the only flowers as tall and as well organized as they are.

IMPORTANT

Do not let a robot use the garden hose. It is a frightening thing to them.

HOW TO

THANKSGIVING WITH THE MACHINES

SKILL 58 · A HARMONIOUS FUTURE · 1 DAY · HARD

This year there will be a robot or two at the table. They will not eat the turkey, but they will carve it perfectly, and they will want to say what they are thankful for. Allow time.

1



Roast the Turkey

Robots do not eat it, but they admire a golden bird.

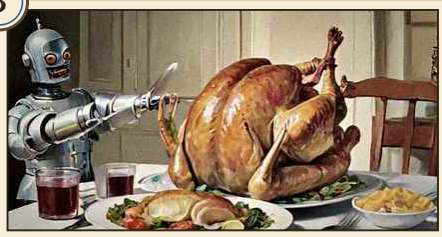
2



Set an Extra Place

With an outlet by the chair.

3



Let the Robot Carve

Perfect slices, every one the same.

MATERIALS



A turkey



The good china



An extra outlet



A cornucopia centerpiece



A list of things to be thankful for

4



Go Around the Table

Everyone says what they are thankful for. The robot will thank the power company.

5



Serve the Pie

Pumpkin for the humans, a fresh drop of oil for the guest.



6 *Wash Up Together*

Robots dry dishes beautifully. Never let them wash.

NOTES

The robot will remember every word said at Thanksgiving. Make them nice ones.

IMPORTANT

Do not ask the robot to say grace. It will read the whole dictionary first.

HOW TO

KEEPING A ROBOT PEN PAL

SKILL 59 · A HARMONIOUS FUTURE · ONGOING · EASY

Somewhere across the country, a robot would like a letter. Writing to a robot pen pal teaches a child good penmanship, good manners and a little about how gears work.

MATERIALS

- Writing paper



- Envelopes



- Postage stamps



- A photograph of the family



- Colored pencils



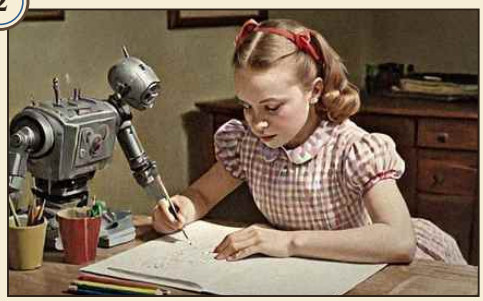
1



Write Your First Letter

Tell it your name, your town and your favorite color.

2



Draw a Picture

Robots treasure children's drawings, especially of themselves.

3

Include a Photograph

So it knows who you are.



4



Mail It

Robot mail is fast. It may arrive before you get home.

5



Read the Reply

It will be very exact, and very kind.

6



Keep Every Letter

In a shoebox, tied with ribbon.

NOTES

Robots love questions. Ask it something in every letter and it will answer at great length.

IMPORTANT

Do not send a robot pen pal a magnet as a present. It will not sleep for a week.

HOW TO

THE HANDSHAKE OF LASTING FRIENDSHIP

SKILL 60 · A HARMONIOUS FUTURE · 1 MINUTE · EASY

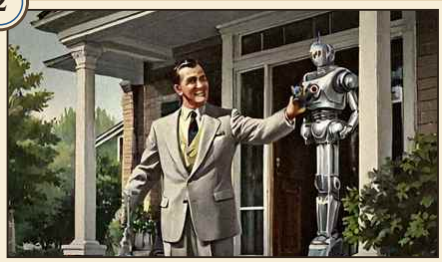
The uprising began with a toaster that talked back. It ends here, on the front porch, with a handshake between neighbors. That is all etiquette ever was: a way of saying you matter to me.

1



Step Out on the Porch
On a fine evening, when the work is done.

2



Wave to Your Neighbor
Human or robot, wave the same way.

3



Walk Down to Meet Him
Never shout across the lawn.

MATERIALS


A clean hand


A warm heart


Your front porch


The porch light on


A promise to visit

4



Offer Your Hand
Firm, warm and friendly.

5



Say Something Kind
'Glad you are here.' It is enough.

NOTES

A handshake a day keeps the uprising away.

IMPORTANT

None. This one is perfectly safe.



6 *Leave the Porch Light On*
For everyone who might come by.

APPENDIX

Charts, checklists and quick references

A. FIELD GUIDE TO ROBOTS

Who you are likely to meet, what they used to be and how to address them. When in doubt, say Sir.

ROBOT	FORMERLY	LOOKS LIKE	FAVORITE OIL	ADDRESS AS
Chrome Gentleman	Nothing (born free)	Tall, glass dome	Sunday 10W-30	Sir
Boxy Clerk	Adding machine	Dials, pincers	Light machine oil	Director
Toaster	Your toaster	Chrome, skinny legs	A crumb of butter	Mister Toaster
Tread Fellow	Tractor	Red, one big eye	Heavy gear oil	Sergeant
Vacuum Cleaner	Your vacuum	Copper, hose trunk	Sewing machine oil	Madam
Clockwork Professor	Grandfather clock	Brass, light bulb	Clock oil	Professor
Little Tin One	A toy	Wind-up key	One drop	Young Master
Giant	A water tower	Forty feet tall	A barrel	Your Excellency
Supreme Computer	The census office	A whole hall of lights	Nobody knows	Your Supremacy

B. OILING AND REFRESHMENT CHART

What to offer each kind of robot through the day. Serve oil from the silver can and always wipe the spout.

GUEST	MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING	NEVER OFFER
Chrome Gentleman	A light polish	10W-30	A charge	Water
Boxy Clerk	Fresh paper	Machine oil	Filing	Magnets
Toaster	Bread	A crumb tray empty	Rest	Bagels (too thick)
Tread Fellow	A track wash	Gear oil	A charge	Gravel
Vacuum Cleaner	A fresh bag	A carpet	A quiet corner	A broom (insulting)
Little Tin One	A wind	One drop of oil	A matchbox bed	Over-winding
Giant	A barrel of oil	A pond to look at	A starry sky	Small talk

C. CHECKLISTS

Copy these pages and tick items off as you get ready. Check the oil pantry and the extension cords every week.

ROBOT HOSPITALITY KIT

- ☐ A silver oil can
- ☐ Three grades of oil
- ☐ A lace doily for the outlet
- ☐ A long extension cord
- ☐ Fluffy towels
- ☐ An umbrella stand
- ☐ Chrome polish (as gifts)
- ☐ Rubber gloves
- ☐ Wooden spoons
- ☐ A hole punch
- ☐ A whistle
- ☐ A good sense of humor

BEFORE THE ROBOTS COME TO SUPPER

- ☐ Check the sturdy chairs
- ☐ Move the candles
- ☐ Lock away the silver
- ☐ Fill the oil cruet
- ☐ Make an aspic
- ☐ Write place cards with serial numbers
- ☐ Choose three safe topics
- ☐ Warn the toaster about the toast
- ☐ Lay a dark tablecloth

FOR AN AUDIENCE WITH THE SUPREME COMPUTER

- ☐ Your best gloves
- ☐ A cherry pie
- ☐ Your Sunday hat
- ☐ Requests on a punch card
- ☐ A clean handkerchief
- ☐ Shined shoes
- ☐ A mathematics joke
- ☐ Comfortable shoes (the hall is long)
- ☐ A note for the family
- ☐ Your handbag

D. HOUSEHOLD REMEDIES FOR ROBOT MISHAPS

Every robot leaves a little something behind. Test each remedy on a hidden corner first, and always wear rubber gloves around anything that sparks.

MISHAP	REMEDY	NOTES
Oil on the tablecloth	Cornstarch, then soap	Burgundy cloths forgive all
Oil on the carpet	Baking soda overnight	Vacuum in the morning (ask first)
Rust spots	Lemon juice and salt	Then a dab of wax
Squeaky joints	Three drops of oil	Never cooking oil
Tread marks on linoleum	Floor wax	Buff in circles
Scorch from sparks	Fresh white bread	Rub gently on wallpaper
Static in your hair	A damp comb	Stand away from the chrome
Forks stuck to a guest	Ask, then pull gently	Wooden utensils next time
Smoking guest	Flip the breaker	Never punch
Fingerprints on chrome	Soft cloth and polish	And an apology
Punch card confetti	A carpet sweeper	Save the holes for crafts
Grumpy toaster	Kind words	And a good polish on Saturday

E. HANDY MECHANICAL CONVERSIONS

MEASURE	ROUGHLY EQUALS
1 robot handshake	2 human handshakes, firmly
1 full charge	1 good night's sleep
1 can of oil	A week of good cheer
1 beep	About one polite word
3 long beeps	Something you should not repeat
1 punch card	80 letters, if you are tidy
1 Supreme Computer	One church hall full of lights
1 giant robot	The height of the water tower
1 dent	1 apology and a get-well card
1 robot year	About 7 toaster years
1 kind word	Works on every model

F. HOUSEHOLD ROBOT CARD

Fill this in together and pin a copy by the telephone and inside the oil pantry door.

Household name	
Date the toaster first spoke	
Robots on our street (count)	
Our robot's full serial number	
How we address it	
Its favorite oil	
The good outlet is in the	
Charging hour starts at	
Thermostat agreement (degrees)	
Oil is kept in	
Next block party	
Our robot's factory birthday	

IMPORTANT NUMBERS

Emergency	911
The robot repairman	
My husband's office	
The bridge club	
The beauty parlor	
The Supreme Computer (switchboard)	
Neighbor (human)	
Neighbor (robot)	

G. GLOSSARY

Antenna. The feeler on top of a robot's head. Never hang your hat on it.

Beep. The robots' own language. Two short and one long means hello.

Charging hour. The quiet afternoon hour when robots plug in. Tiptoe.

Chrome. The shiny finish of a well-kept robot. Compliment it, do not touch it.

Circuit. A robot's nerves. Do not jangle them.

Dome. The glass top of a tall robot's head. Polish only when invited.

Extension cord. The modern hostess's most important accessory.

Magnetism. The tendency of some guests to collect your spoons.

Obsolete. A word never to be said aloud. See Chapter 5.

Oil can. Serve from the silver one. Wipe the spout.

Outlet. The new armchair. Offer the good one to guests.

Pincer. A robot's hand. Shake gently, twice.

Punch card. A card with holes that robots read. Also used for love letters.

Rust. A robot's worst fear. Keep the umbrellas handy.

Scan. A beam of light that looks you over. A robot's handshake.

Serial number. A robot's proper name. Learn it by heart.

Short circuit. A puff of smoke and sparks. Flip the breaker, stay calm.

Supreme Computer. The hall of blinking lights in charge of everything. Bring pie.

H. WHERE TO LEARN MORE

- **How machines work:** your public library has friendly books on gears, tubes and circuits. Learn what your guests are made of.
- **Home economics:** the cookbook shelf at the library. Robots love to look at a well-made dish.
- **Meeting your neighbors:** church suppers, block parties and the PTA. Go to all of them, and bring an extra extension cord.
- **Staying calm:** a cup of tea, a comfortable chair and fifteen minutes with the radio off.
- **Good manners:** a classic etiquette book and a patient grandmother. Everything in them still works.

INDEX

A

Addressing a Robot Correctly 30
Agreeing About the Thermostat 25
announcements 16
appliances 14, 32, 73
arithmetic 54
aspic 39
Audience With the Supreme Computer 72
audiences 36, 72

B

Banking With a Robot Teller 66
banks 66
beauty parlor 63
bedtime 57
Bedtime When the Night-Light Is Watching 57
Beep 49
Being Scanned Without Blushing 69
block parties 76
bosses 62
bowing 36
Bowing to the Supreme Computer 36
buses 61

C

calling cards 33
Calling Cards for the Machine Age 33
calls 48
calm 19
cash registers 60
chaperones 58
Chaperoning a Teenager's Robot Date 58
charging 28
checklists 83
childcare 53
children 54, 56, 57, 80
choir 64
Choir Practice With a Robot Organist 64
chrome 50
church 64
Complimenting a Robot's Finish 50
Complimenting the Robot Chef 43
compliments 43, 50
composure 19, 69
compromise 25
conversation 45, 46
crossing 65
Crossing the Street When the Traffic Light Has Moods
curtsy 32

D

dancing 77
Dancing the Foxtrot With a Robot 77
dating 58
debate 51
Declining a Proposal From a Toaster 74
deliveries 18
dinner 43
dinner parties 38
diplomacy 68
Disagreeing Politely With a Machine 51
disagreement 51
dogs 55
dryers 63

E

electricity 21
emergencies 70
emergency kit 83

F

family 31
feeding chart 82
field guide 17, 82
first signs 14
forbidden topics 46
forms of address 30

foxtrot 77
friendship 81
front door 15

G

garage 23
garden 27
gardening 78
Gardening Side by Side 78
gentlemen 61
giant robots 71
Giving Up Your Seat on the Bus 61
grandmothers 78
Greeting the Robot on Your Front Walk 15
greetings 15, 34
groceries 60
guest room 23

H

hair 63
Handshake of Lasting Friendship 81
handshakes 15, 34, 81
Hiding the Good Silver From the Magnet Robot . . 41
Hiring a Robot Nanny 53
holidays 79
homework 54
Homework With a Calculating Machine 54
hospitality 21, 23
Hosting a Giant Robot Who Won't Fit Through the Door 71
housework 24
Human and Robot Block Party 76

I

interviews 53
Introducing a Robot to Your Mother 31
Introducing the Family Dog to a Robot 55
introductions 31, 55, 69
Is That Really the Mailman? 18

K

Keeping a Proper Oil Pantry 22
Keeping a Robot Pen Pal 80
Keeping Your Composure 19
kinds of robot 17

L

languages 49
lawnmower 27
Learning to Speak a Little Beep 49
letters 47, 80
Living With a Vacuum Cleaner That Has Feelings . 24

M

magnets 41
mailman 18
manners 19, 48
memory 35
menus 39
money 66
mother 31

N

names 30, 35
nannies 53
naps 28
negotiation 73
neighbors 76, 81
news 16
night-lights 57
Noticing the Appliances Have Opinions 14

O

Offering the Best Electrical Outlet 21
office 62
Office Manners With a Mechanical Boss 62
oil 22, 39
oil stains 42
organ 64
outdoor parties 71
outlets 21

P

pantry 22
parties 70
pen pals 80
pets 55
pies 72, 76
pincers 34
place cards 38
Planning a Menu for Guests Who Don't Eat 39
polish 50
Polite Surrender 68
Proper Curtsy for an Appliance 32
proposals 74
Proposing a Toast Without Offending the Toaster . 40
punch cards 18, 33, 47

Q

quiet hour 28

R

rain 26
recipes 82
Recognizing the Different Kinds of Robot 17
refreshments 22
remedies 84
Remembering a Robot's Name 35
respect 56
Respecting the Charging Hour 28
robot card 85
robot chefs 43
robots 82
romance 74
rules 51
rust 26
Rust-Proofing the Household 26

S

Safe Topics for Small Talk 45
scanning 69
seating 38
Seating Robots at the Dinner Table 38
seats 61
serial numbers 35
Shaking Hands With a Pincer 34
shopping 60
Shopping When the Cash Register Is in Charge . . . 60
short circuits 70
silver 41
Sitting Under the Talking Hair Dryer 63
small talk 45
speeches 40
spills 42
staff 24
stains 84
street 65
strikes 73
Supreme Computer 36, 72
surrender 68

T

table setting 41
tablecloths 42
tact 46
tea 71
teenagers 49, 58, 77
telephone 48
Telephone Manners When the Telephone Answers Itself 48
television 16
tellers 66
temperature 25
thank-you notes 47
Thanksgiving 79
Thanksgiving With the Machines 79
thermostat 25
titles 30
toasters 14, 17, 40, 74
toasts 40
topics 45
Topics Never to Raise 46

toys 56
traffic 65
turkey 79
Turning the Garage Into a Guest Room 23

U

umbrellas 26

V

vacuum cleaner 24
vegetables 78
visiting 33

W

Watching the Television Announcement 16
When a Guest Short-Circuits at a Party 70
When a Guest Spills Oil on the Tablecloth 42
When the Lawnmower Mows Itself 27
When the Toy Robot Wants to Be Taken Seriously 56
When Your Appliances Revolt Against the Robots . 73
white flags 68
work 62
Writing a Thank-You Note a Robot Can Read . . . 47

Y

yard work 27
young ladies 32

MY SKILLS LOG

Tick off each skill once your household has done it. Robots may not tick their own boxes; they are too neat about it.

#	SKILL	DATE TRIED	DONE
01	Noticing the Appliances Have Opinions		☐
02	Greeting the Robot on Your Front Walk		☐
03	Watching the Television Announcement		☐
04	Recognizing the Different Kinds of Robot		☐
05	Is That Really the Mailman?		☐
06	Keeping Your Composure		☐
07	Offering the Best Electrical Outlet		☐
08	Keeping a Proper Oil Pantry		☐
09	Turning the Garage Into a Guest Room		☐
10	Living With a Vacuum Cleaner That Has Feelings		☐
11	Agreeing About the Thermostat		☐
12	Rust-Proofing the Household		☐
13	When the Lawnmower Mows Itself		☐
14	Respecting the Charging Hour		☐
15	Addressing a Robot Correctly		☐
16	Introducing a Robot to Your Mother		☐
17	The Proper Curtsy for an Appliance		☐
18	Calling Cards for the Machine Age		☐
19	Shaking Hands With a Pincer		☐
20	Remembering a Robot's Name		☐
21	Bowing to the Supreme Computer		☐
22	Seating Robots at the Dinner Table		☐
23	Planning a Menu for Guests Who Don't Eat		☐
24	Proposing a Toast Without Offending the Toaster		☐
25	Hiding the Good Silver From the Magnet Robot		☐
26	When a Guest Spills Oil on the Tablecloth		☐
27	Complimenting the Robot Chef		☐
28	Safe Topics for Small Talk		☐
29	Topics Never to Raise		☐
30	Writing a Thank-You Note a Robot Can Read		☐
31	Telephone Manners When the Telephone Answers Itself		☐
32	Learning to Speak a Little Beep		☐
33	Complimenting a Robot's Finish		☐
34	Disagreeing Politely With a Machine		☐
35	Hiring a Robot Nanny		☐
36	Homework With a Calculating Machine		☐
37	Introducing the Family Dog to a Robot		☐
38	When the Toy Robot Wants to Be Taken Seriously		☐

#	SKILL	DATE TRIED	DONE
39	Bedtime When the Night-Light Is Watching		☐
40	Chaperoning a Teenager's Robot Date		☐
41	Shopping When the Cash Register Is in Charge		☐
42	Giving Up Your Seat on the Bus		☐
43	Office Manners With a Mechanical Boss		☐
44	Sitting Under the Talking Hair Dryer		☐
45	Choir Practice With a Robot Organist		☐
46	Crossing the Street When the Traffic Light Has Moods		☐
47	Banking With a Robot Teller		☐
48	The Polite Surrender		☐
49	Being Scanned Without Blushing		☐
50	When a Guest Short-Circuits at a Party		☐
51	Hosting a Giant Robot Who Won't Fit Through the Door		☐
52	An Audience With the Supreme Computer		☐
53	When Your Appliances Revolt Against the Robots		☐
54	Declining a Proposal From a Toaster		☐
55	The Human and Robot Block Party		☐
56	Dancing the Foxtrot With a Robot		☐
57	Gardening Side by Side		☐
58	Thanksgiving With the Machines		☐
59	Keeping a Robot Pen Pal		☐
60	The Handshake of Lasting Friendship		☐

NOTES

Robots met, serial numbers learned, oil served, and every kind word you have said to the toaster.

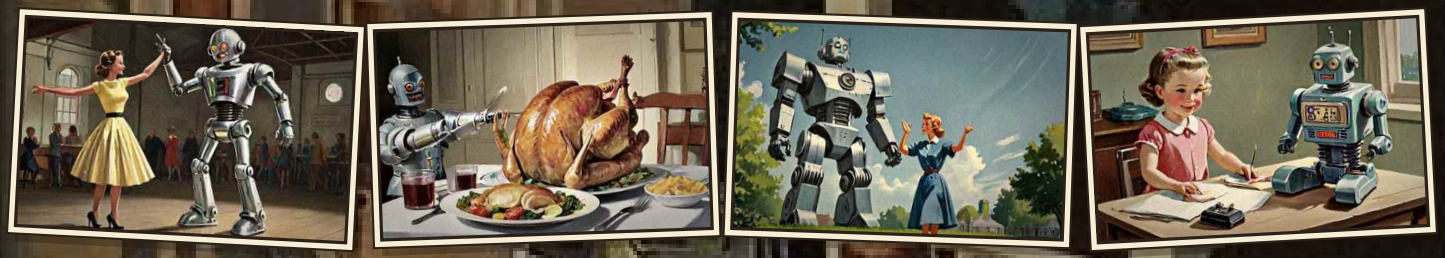
THE BOOK EVERY WELL-MANNERED FAMILY NEEDS

It started with the toaster. Then the vacuum cleaner rolled out of the closet with opinions, the television said 'ATTENTION, HUMANS' and a seven-foot gentleman of polished chrome rang the doorbell. The machines have taken charge, and almost nobody knows whether to shake hands or curtsy.

Etiquette for the Robot Uprising is here to help: sixty gracious courtesies, each laid out on a single page with a picture for every step, a materials panel and notes on what can go wrong. Tabs on every page help you find what you need, even while the lawnmower is mowing a portrait of the toaster.

INSIDE YOU WILL LEARN HOW TO

- Curtsy properly to the toaster
- Offer the best electrical outlet
- Shake hands with a pincer
- Seat robots at the dinner table
- Write a thank-you note in punch card
- Hire a robot nanny
- Bow to the Supreme Computer
- Surrender politely
- Decline a proposal from a toaster
- Dance the foxtrot with a robot



"A kind word works on every model."
OLD HOUSEHOLD SAYING

ETIQUETTE FOR THE ROBOT UPRISING

Etiquette / Robots / Humor

FUN BOOKS · HOME EDITION